Homo Anaestheticus

Price, Immunity, and the Unnarrated *Who* in *American Psycho*

A theory of anaesthetic sovereignty and the feminist remainder

On Bret Easton Ellis's novel (1991) and
Mary Harron and Guinevere Turner's film (2000)

A dissertation

October 2026

Contents

Abstract 3

Introduction: The Threshold Problem 5

I. Genealogies of the Anaesthetic Subject 10

1 Underground, Inferno, No Exit: The Epigraphic Contract 11

2 Juliette in Armani: Sadean Apathy, Enlightenment Reason, and the Failure of Transgression 15

3 The Blasé Metropolis and the Economy of Persons 20

4 Narcissus at the End of History 25

II. The Text as Theory 29

5 The Itemized Subject: Catalog, Card, Routine, Review 30

6 A Critique of Pure Price: Dignity, Face, Fungibility 34

7 The Cannibal Ledger: Social Reproduction and the Political Economy of the Female Body 39

8 Crime Without Punishment: Dostoevsky, Becker, and the Undecidable Ledger 44

III. Controversy and Counter-Adaptation 49

9 Must We Burn Bateman? The 1990–91 Controversy and the Feminist Sex Wars 50

10 The Gaze Returned: Harron and Turner's Counter-Adaptation 55

IV. Comparative Horizons and Synthesis 60

11 Which Humanism Survives Bateman? Feminist and Humanist Counter-Texts 61

12 Homo Anaestheticus: A Theory of Anaesthetic Sovereignty and the Feminist Remainder 67

Coda: After the Exit: The Idea of a Patrick Bateman in Circulation 73

Conclusion 76

Works Cited 78

Keywords 87

Abstract

This dissertation argues that American Psycho*—Bret Easton Ellis's novel* (*1991*) *and Mary Harron and Guinevere Turner's film adaptation* (*2000*)*, read here as a single, internally agonistic diptych—constitutes the most rigorous literary-cinematic theorization of a figure this study names* homo anaestheticus*: the subject produced when the Kantian distinction between price* (Preis) *and dignity* (Würde) *collapses wholly into price, and the person thereby forfeits the two capacities that, from Aristotle's* aisthēsis *to Levinas's ethics of the face, have grounded the very concept of the human—the capacity to be affected, and the capacity to register as an agent within a shared world.*

Against the three paradigms that have governed reception—the satirical (the novel as an indictment of Reagan-era consumerism), the obscenity-critical (the novel as misogynist incitement, in the tradition of Dworkin and MacKinnon), and the psychiatric (Patrick Bateman as a case of narcissistic or psychopathic disorder)—the thesis advances a theory of *anaesthetic sovereignty*: a condition in which a subject constituted entirely by commodities becomes immune in four interlocking registers. He is affectively immune (he cannot feel), ethically immune (he cannot perceive the face of the other), socio-juridically immune (his acts do not register as acts), and aesthetically immune (the forms that represent him numb the reader who encounters them). The notorious undecidability of the novel's murders is accordingly reinterpreted not as a hermeneutic puzzle awaiting solution but as the formal transcription of class impunity: where no institution records the killing of the dispossessed, the distinction between act and fantasy becomes socially inoperative. The study names this condition *credibility immunity*, the structural obverse of Miranda Fricker's testimonial injustice.

Tracing a genealogy that runs from Sade's doctrine of apathy, Kant's kingdom of ends and Swift's cannibal satire through Veblen, Simmel, Weber, Marx, Lukács, Benjamin, Arendt, Debord, Baudrillard, Jameson and Fukuyama, and placing the corpus in sustained dialogue with feminist theory (Beauvoir, Millett, Rubin, Mulvey, Dworkin, MacKinnon, Adams, Butler, Clover, Williams, Federici, Fraser,

hooks, Ahmed, Cavarero) and with the humanist tradition and its decolonial critics (Pico, Kant, Wollstonecraft, Whitman, Fromm, Césaire, Fanon, Wynter), the dissertation makes three further claims.

First, Bateman's violence is distributed with uncanny precision across the four "background conditions" that Nancy Fraser identifies as the substrates capital devours—social reproduction, expropriated populations, nature, and public power—so that his cannibalism literalizes what Fraser calls cannibal capitalism; the study terms this distribution the *cannibal ledger*. Second, the murders constitute a *failed empirical metaphysics*: the attempt to locate, inside the bodies of others, the dignity that an ontology of pure price cannot otherwise admit—an attempt that discovers only matter and thereby confirms its own premise. Third, Harron and Turner's adaptation is not a softening but a counter-text: it returns the camera's gaze to the male body, converts horror into a comedy that exposes (with Bergson) the "anesthesia of the heart" on which laughter itself depends, and installs within the narrative a female witness, Jean, whose look supplies the recognition the novel's world withholds.

The dissertation concludes by proposing a *feminist humanism of the who*—grounded not in the autonomous, self-fashioning subject of Renaissance and Enlightenment humanism, which Bateman exposes as complicit, but in vulnerability, narratable uniqueness and grievability (Arendt, Cavarero, Butler, Fineman)—and by reading the text's twenty-first-century memetic afterlife, in which "an idea of a Patrick Bateman" circulates as an aspirational template, as the realization of the novel's own prophecy. The ethical task of reading *American Psycho* is finally defined as *exhumation*: the restoration of the ledger's unnamed dead to the status of persons.

Introduction

The Threshold Problem

i. Two Inscriptions

American Psycho is bracketed by two inscriptions that together pose the problem this dissertation pursues. The novel opens with Dante's admonition to those who pass the gate of Hell—*lasciate ogne speranza, voi ch'intrate* (*Inferno* III.9)—scrawled in red across the façade of a Chemical Bank branch; it closes with a sign above a door in Harry's bar: THIS IS NOT AN EXIT. Between the theological threshold and the regulatory placard lies the entire text, which is therefore structured as an entrance without egress. The first inscription cites the Christian-humanist cosmos in which damnation is a legible architecture of justice, every sin matched to its *contrapasso*; the second is a fire-code notice, the language of insurance and building management. The trajectory from one to the other compresses a history of the sacred into four hundred pages: Hell has ceased to be an order of retribution and become an order of administration. Sartre's *Huis clos* (1944) had already relocated damnation from the cosmos to the drawing room; Ellis relocates it to the bar tab and the lobby.

The dissertation names this structure the *threshold problem*. Every boundary the text invokes fails to hold: between act and fantasy, person and commodity, satire and complicity, reader and read, the novel and the film that both adapts and indicts it. The failure is not a defect of execution but the text's object of knowledge. *American Psycho* is a work about thresholds that no longer separate, written at the historical moment when the principal institutions of separation—law, shame, taste, class distinction, the confessional—were being reorganized under the sign of the market.

ii. Corpus and Textual History

The primary corpus comprises Ellis's novel, published by Vintage Contemporaries in March 1991, and the film directed by Mary Harron from a screenplay by Harron and Guinevere Turner, premiered at the Sundance Film Festival in January 2000 and released by Lions Gate Films that April. The novel's publication history is itself a primary document. Contracted by Simon & Schuster for a reported advance of $300,000, the manuscript was withdrawn in November 1990 after excerpts circulated in the press and provoked public outrage; Sonny Mehta acquired it for Knopf's Vintage imprint within days. Before a single copy had been sold, Roger Rosenblatt's *New York Times Book Review* polemic, "Snuff This Book!", had framed the text as an ethical emergency, and the Los Angeles chapter of the National Organization for Women, under Tammy Bruce, had called for a boycott of the publisher. Norman Mailer's long essay in *Vanity Fair* (March 1991) conceded the book's seriousness while faulting its refusal of interiority; Fay Weldon and, most consequentially, Elizabeth Young (1992) defended it as moral satire. In Australia it was sold shrink-wrapped and age-restricted.

The film's history is comparably fraught. Produced by Edward R. Pressman, the project passed through a period in which Harron was displaced in favor of a star-driven version with Leonardo DiCaprio, before reverting to Harron and her chosen lead, Christian Bale. It received an NC-17 rating for a single sexual sequence, trimmed to secure an R. The corpus extends, as secondary material, to Ellis's return to Bateman in *Glamorama* (1998) and *Lunar Park* (2005); to the unrelated direct-to-video sequel *American Psycho 2* (2002); to the stage musical by Duncan Sheik and Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa (London, 2013; Broadway, 2016); and to the memetic afterlife examined in the Coda.

The novel and film are treated here neither as original and copy nor as source and interpretation, but as a diptych in agonistic relation: two panels painted by different hands, from different gendered positions, a decade apart, which together constitute a single argument that neither makes alone.

iii. Three Critical Paradigms and Their Limits

Reception has been organized by three paradigms, each of which captures something essential and forecloses something more essential still.

The *satirical paradigm* (Young 1992; Annesley 1998; Murphet 2002; Baelo-Allué 2011) reads the novel as a Juvenalian assault on the consumer culture of the Reagan years, its violence the literalization of the metaphorical violence of finance. Its limit is theoretical: satire, as Northrop Frye (1957) insisted, is militant irony whose moral norms are relatively clear. *American Psycho* contains no such norm. No character,

narrator or implied author articulates a standard against which Bateman is measured. The text is what Fredric Jameson (1991) would call *blank* satire—parody that has lost its laughter and its norm alike—and the satirical reading must therefore explain where the absent norm resides. This dissertation locates it in the body of the reader.

The *obscenity-critical paradigm*, articulated in the 1990–91 controversy and grounded in the anti-pornography feminism of Andrea Dworkin (1981) and Catharine MacKinnon (1987, 1993), treats the novel's depictions of sexualized torture as acts of subordination rather than representations of it. Its limit lies in its indifference to form: it reads the sentence without the paragraph, the scene without the architecture of revulsion in which it is embedded. Yet it registers what the satirical paradigm habitually aestheticizes—that the violence of the text is not distributed at random but falls overwhelmingly on women, on the poor, and on the racialized, and that this distribution is itself an argument requiring analysis.

The *psychiatric paradigm* reads Bateman through clinical taxonomies: Hervey Cleckley's *The Mask of Sanity* (1941), whose notion of "semantic dementia"—the psychopath's fluency with words whose affective meaning he cannot feel—describes Bateman's speech with eerie exactness; the narcissistic personality disorder codified in *DSM-III-R* (1987); Robert Hare's Psychopathy Checklist-Revised, published, as it happens, in the same year as the novel. Its limit is that it individualizes what the text insists is social. Christopher Lasch (1979) had already argued that the narcissistic personality is the characteristic product of late capitalism rather than its aberration; the popular literature of the "corporate psychopath" (Babiak and Hare 2006) later confirmed, inadvertently, that the clinical description and the job description had converged.

A fourth, more recent tendency—affective and post-representational (Abel 2001, 2007; Serpell 2010)—proposes that the novel's violence be met not with moral judgment but with an attention to intensities that suspends judgment altogether. This dissertation engages that tendency directly in Chapter 12, arguing that neither judgment (moralism) nor its suspension (neutrality) but *aesthesis*—the restored capacity to be affected—is the text's ethical horizon.

iv. Method: Convergent Genealogy

The method is a *convergent genealogy*. It traces, on the one hand, the originators whose ideas the text explicitly inherits—through its epigraphs (Dostoevsky), its framing citations (Dante), its titular and nominal allusions (Hitchcock's *Psycho*, whose Norman Bates haunts the surname Bateman), its intertexts (Tom Wolfe's *The Bonfire of the Vanities*, from which Ellis borrows Bateman's employer, Pierce & Pierce)—and, on the other, the bodies of thought with which the text converges without citation. Following Walter Benjamin's and Theodor Adorno's practice of the *constellation*, the analysis treats the novel not as an illustration of theory but as a theoretical object in its own right: a work that thinks in narrative what philosophy thinks in concepts.

The convergences are, in the first instance, chronological. The years 1989–1992 constitute an extraordinary conjuncture. Linda Williams's *Hard Core* (1989); Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* and Carol J. Adams's *The Sexual Politics of Meat* (1990); Susan Faludi's *Backlash*, Jameson's *Postmodernism*, Hare's checklist, Jonathan Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs* and *American Psycho* itself (1991); Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws*, Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man*, Axel Honneth's *The Struggle for Recognition* and Susan Buck-Morss's "Aesthetics and Anaesthetics" (1992): the novel sits at the node of a theoretical moment that it did not read but that read the same world. The film, in turn, is contemporaneous with Susan Bordo's *The Male Body*, Faludi's *Stiffed* and David Fincher's *Fight Club* (all 1999)—the first sustained cultural reckoning with the commodified male body.

v. Thesis and Lexicon

The argument can be stated in a single proposition. *American Psycho* depicts the completion of a process—begun in Aristotle's suspicion of money that breeds money, named by Kant as the conversion of dignity into price, analyzed by Marx as commodity fetishism and by Simmel as the blasé attitude—in which the human subject becomes wholly fungible and therefore wholly anaesthetic; the violence of such a subject falls on the reproductive, expropriated and natural substrates of the economy that produced him; his acts are undecidable because they are unregistrable; and the only resistance the text admits is a remainder—bodily, testimonial and feminist—that a new humanism must take as its foundation.

The argument deploys a lexicon of coined terms, defined as they arise: *homo anaestheticus*; *anaesthetic sovereignty*; the *itemized subject*; *credibility immunity*; the *cannibal ledger*; *failed empirical metaphysics*; *somatic satire*; the *feminist remainder*; the *humanism of the who*; and *reading as exhumation*.

vi. Plan of the Work

Part One reconstructs the genealogy. Chapter 1 reads the novel's epigraphic apparatus and its Dantean, Dostoevskian and Sartrean frames as a theology of the threshold transposed into administration. Chapter 2 places Bateman in the lineage of Sade and of the Frankfurt School's critique of Enlightenment reason, arguing that Sadean apathy, once an ascetic achievement, has become a consumer good. Chapter 3 assembles the sociology of money and the metropolis from Veblen and Simmel to Baudrillard and Jameson. Chapter 4 situates Bateman at Fukuyama's "end of history," as Nietzsche's last man failing the Hegelian struggle for recognition.

Part Two reads the text as theory. Chapter 5 analyzes the catalog, the business card, the morning routine and the music chapters as the formal apparatus of the itemized subject. Chapter 6 offers a "critique of pure price," setting Kant, Levinas, Nussbaum, Arendt and Cavarero against the novel's economy of faces. Chapter 7 reconstructs the cannibal ledger through feminist political economy, from Rubin and Federici to Adams and Fraser. Chapter 8 reads the undecidability of the murders through Dostoevsky, Gary Becker, Fricker, Esposito and Benjamin.

Part Three turns to controversy and adaptation. Chapter 9 revisits the 1990–91 scandal through the feminist sex wars and Beauvoir's question, "Must we burn Sade?". Chapter 10 reads Harron and Turner's film as a counter-adaptation that returns the gaze.

Part Four widens and synthesizes. Chapter 11 asks which humanism survives Bateman. Chapter 12 articulates the theory of anaesthetic sovereignty and the feminist remainder. A Coda reads the memetic afterlife; the Conclusion assesses the contribution.

Part One

I

Genealogies of the Anaesthetic Subject

1 Underground, Inferno, No Exit: The Epigraphic Contract

2 Juliette in Armani: Sadean Apathy, Enlightenment Reason, and the Failure of Transgression

3 The Blasé Metropolis and the Economy of Persons

4 Narcissus at the End of History

1

Underground, Inferno, No Exit

The Epigraphic Contract

The novel's paratextual apparatus establishes a theology of the threshold and then transposes it, clause by clause, into the language of administration; the chapter reads the epigraphs and the Dantean, Dostoevskian, Sartrean and Kierkegaardian frames as the terms of a contract the text proceeds to breach.

1.1 Three Clauses

The novel bears three epigraphs: the authorial note to Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* (1864), which concedes that its narrator is fictional while insisting that such persons not only may but must exist, given the circumstances under which society has been formed; a passage from Judith Martin's "Miss Manners" column locating civility in the mannerly containment of impulse; and a lyric from Talking Heads' "(Nothing But) Flowers" (1988) concerning a collapse that proceeds without anyone much noticing. Read as a contract, the three clauses stipulate *sociogenesis* (the subject is produced by his society), *form* (manners restrain what would otherwise erupt), and *reception* (the catastrophe will pass unremarked).

The sequence is already an argument. That a Russian novelist, an etiquette columnist and a New Wave band occupy a single page enacts what Andreas Huyssen (1986) called the collapse of the "great divide" between modernism and mass culture; the epigraphs perform, before the narrative begins, the leveling of hierarchy that the narrative will extend to persons. The second clause is the most precisely falsified. Norbert Elias's *The Civilizing Process* (1939) reconstructed the history of manners as the progressive internalization of affect-control, the conversion of external constraint into self-constraint. Bateman represents the terminus of that process: affect-control so total that no affect remains to be

controlled. His violence does not erupt through a failure of restraint, as the civility thesis presumes; it emerges from the vacancy restraint leaves behind once it has nothing left to restrain. He is the first wholly *mannerly* psychopath, and the novel is the Eliasian process run to its asymptote.

1.2 The Underground and the Crystal Palace

The Underground Man is defined by hyperconsciousness and paralysis: he thinks too much to act, and his only freedom is spite. His antagonist is the Crystal Palace—the utopia of rational self-interest that Chernyshevsky's *What Is to Be Done?* (1863) modeled on Joseph Paxton's building for the Great Exhibition of 1851—in which human beings, their desires calculated in advance, would become piano keys. Against it he asserts caprice, insisting that twice two makes four is not life but the beginning of death.

Bateman is the Underground Man's photographic negative: action without consciousness rather than consciousness without action. The decisive point is architectural. The Crystal Palace was, literally, an exhibition hall of commodities; Benjamin would later describe world exhibitions as places of pilgrimage to the commodity fetish. The Underground Man stood outside it and refused to enter. Bateman was born inside it. His caprice—the murders—cannot be a revolt against the Palace because it is one of the Palace's amusements; it is spite without a standpoint, a piano key that strikes itself. Dostoevsky's epigraph thereby undergoes an ironic intensification: if the Underground Man was a socially necessary product of Russian modernization, Bateman is the socially necessary product of a society that has abolished the outside from which spite was possible.

1.3 Inferno: The Bank and the Usurers' Purses

That Dante's inscription appears on the wall of a bank is not incidental. In the seventh circle of the *Inferno*, among the violent against God, nature and art, sit the usurers, crouched on burning sand. Dante, peering into their faces, recognizes none of them; he identifies them only by the purses hung from their necks, each bearing a family's color and heraldic device—an azure lion on yellow, a white goose on red, a pregnant blue sow on white (*Inferno* XVII.52–65). Their eyes, he notes, seem to feed upon these purses.

This is the first scene in Western literature in which persons are legible by their insignia and illegible by their faces, and it is the medieval prefiguration of Bateman's world, in which men are constantly mistaken for one another while their tailoring is identified to the stitch. The genealogy behind Dante's placement is exact. Aristotle (*Politics* I.10) condemned usury as the most unnatural mode of acquisition

because it makes money breed money, the Greek *tokos* meaning both interest and offspring. Dante classifies usury as violence because it bypasses nature and *arte*, the productive labor that imitates nature. Marx would call interest-bearing capital (M–M′) the most fetish-like form of the capital relation (*Capital* III, ch. 24). Bateman works in mergers and acquisitions at Pierce & Pierce, and the novel never once shows him working: finance appears as a labor of nothing, money begetting money without passing through a world.

The sow belongs to the Scrovegni of Padua, whose heir Enrico commissioned Giotto's Arena Chapel (consecrated 1305), traditionally in expiation of his father's usury. The medieval economy of sin thus possessed a circuit of atonement: usurious wealth could be converted, through art and penance, into grace. Bateman's world has preserved the usury and lost the chapel. His art is investment, his confession reaches an answering machine, and his "contrapasso" is inverted—the sin itself is the reward. Chapter 8 develops this through Benjamin's account of capitalism as a cult that produces guilt without atonement.

1.4 No Exit: Hell Without Others

The closing sign, THIS IS NOT AN EXIT, inverts Sartre's *Huis clos*. Sartre's damned are locked in a drawing room that contains, crucially, no mirrors; Estelle, deprived of her reflection, must see herself through the eyes of Inès, and the play's famous conclusion—that hell is other people—follows from the dependence of each self on the objectifying look of another. Bateman's apartment is a hall of mirrors and his world contains no others: only copies, each of whom mistakes him for someone else. The novel's revision of Sartre is therefore precise. Hell is not other people; hell is the replacement of others by mirrors.

In *Being and Nothingness* (1943), shame is the revelation of being seen: the voyeur at the keyhole, hearing footsteps, discovers himself as an object for another. Bateman, a compulsive voyeur and self-filmer, is never caught at the keyhole. Nobody's look lands on him, so shame—the affect through which, for Sartre, I first acknowledge the other's existence—never arrives. Sartrean bad faith presupposes a consciousness fleeing its own freedom, like the café waiter who overplays his role. Bateman plays his role without reserve, but he also reports that behind the role there is no one—that he simply is not there. This is not bad faith but its exhaustion: a for-itself that has completed its flight into the in-itself, a subject that has become the kind of thing it envies.

1.5 The Aesthete's Diary and the Inverted Stranger

Kierkegaard's *Either/Or* (1843) supplies the existential typology. The aesthete of "Rotation of Crops" identifies boredom as the root of all evil and prescribes arbitrariness as its remedy—a method Bateman follows to its homicidal conclusion. "The Seducer's Diary," presented as a manuscript discovered by an editor, is the canonical found document of cold erotic manipulation; Harron's film will end with Jean discovering Bateman's appointment book filled with drawings of mutilation, restoring the Kierkegaardian frame of the editor who reads the aesthete's record and recoils. *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) diagnoses the despair that does not know itself as despair and, at its extreme, the demonic despair that defiantly wills to be itself. Bateman's closing confession of a constant pain that he wishes others to share is demonic despair in Kierkegaard's strict sense.

Camus's *L'Étranger* (1942) provides the decisive inversion. Meursault is condemned less for killing a man than for failing to weep at his mother's funeral: society demands the performance of affect and executes the man who withholds it. Bateman performs every affect his society demands, flawlessly, and is never condemned. Meursault dies for his authenticity; Bateman is protected by his inauthenticity. Camus opened *The Rebel* (1951) by distinguishing crimes of passion from crimes of logic. Bateman inaugurates a third category, for which this dissertation proposes the name *crimes of consumption*: acts motivated neither by feeling nor by doctrine but by the same circuit of acquisition, display and disposal that governs a purchase.

1.6 From Theodicy to Signage

The apparatus thus constructs a theology of the threshold—Dante's gate, Dostoevsky's underground, Sartre's locked room, Kierkegaard's stages on life's way—only to transpose each element into administration: the bank façade, the etiquette column, the fire-code sign, the answering machine. The sacred has not disappeared from Bateman's world. It has been outsourced to signage.

2

Juliette in Armani

Sadean Apathy, Enlightenment Reason, and the Failure of Transgression

Bateman is a Sadean libertine for whom apathy—once the hard-won summit of an ascetic discipline—has become a standard feature of the commodity world, issued with the suit; what Sade's heroes wrested from God, nature and law, the market now dispenses, and a sovereignty that is dispensed is no sovereignty at all.

2.1 Apathy: From Stoic Discipline to Sadean Sovereignty

The Stoic ideal of *apatheia*, freedom from the passions as the condition of rational self-government, undergoes in Sade a decisive inversion. The libertines of *Juliette* (1797–1801) and *The 120 Days of Sodom* (1785) cultivate apathy not to become virtuous but to become capable of anything: pity is the last remnant of nature's tyranny over the self, and its extinction is the precondition of sovereign crime. Maurice Blanchot's "La raison de Sade" (1949) identified this apathy as the spirit of negation turned upon the self—the sovereign man achieves his sovereignty by destroying in himself the capacity to be moved, and only then negates others. Gilles Deleuze's *Présentation de Sacher-Masoch* (1967) refined the point: Sadism is an *institution* of apathy, and its language is not persuasion but demonstration. The libertine does not seek to convince his victims; he lectures them, proving the necessity of what is about to occur.

Bateman, too, lectures before he kills. Roland Barthes (*Sade, Fourier, Loyola*, 1971) observed that Sade's texts alternate between *scenes* and *dissertations*, orgy and philosophy, with a regularity amounting to a grammar. Ellis preserves the grammar and degrades its content. The dissertations become consumer instruction—Bateman

answering his colleagues' questions about tie bars and collar styles in the cadence of a menswear column—and, in their most notorious form, the chapters on Genesis, Whitney Houston and Huey Lewis and the News, which Harron's film relocates to the moments immediately preceding sex and murder. The Sadean philosopher has become a rock critic, and the demonstration of necessity has become the recitation of a review. The structure survives; the thought has been replaced by taste.

The essential difference is genetic. Sadean apathy is *achieved*, through exercises, regulations and a pedagogy of crime. Bateman's is *issued*: he did not overcome his capacity for pity; he never received it. This is the first and foundational sense in which his condition is anaesthetic rather than apathetic. Apathy is an ascesis; anaesthesia is an amenity.

2.2 The Calendar of Crimes

The 120 Days of Sodom, drafted in the Bastille on a scroll some twelve meters long, is organized as a schedule: four months, six hundred passions graduated from the simple to the murderous, governed by statutes and timetables and inflicted on captives who include sixteen adolescents abducted from their families; the tally at the end of Sade's plan counts thirty of the château's forty-six occupants as killed. Barthes called Sade a *logothete*, a founder of language, whose combinatorics ensure that no position in the scene is left unoccupied. Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno, in the second excursus of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947), read this organizational mania as the truth of bourgeois rationality. Sade's orgies are planned like production; Juliette is the bourgeois subject released from tutelage, who has drawn the consequence Kant could not: a reason that is purely formal, purely instrumental, contains no argument against murder. If reason prescribes means but cannot ground ends, the libertine's calculus is as rational as the categorical imperative and considerably more efficient.

The yuppie inherits this structure in administrative form. Bateman's days are arranged around reservations, appointments and routines whose rhythm the novel's chapter titles reproduce; his violence occurs in the gaps of the planner. Harron makes the inheritance visible in her final sequence, in which the appointment book—the bureaucratic instrument par excellence of the professional-managerial class—turns out to be filled with drawings of dismemberment. The day planner has become *The 120 Days*: a calendar of crimes kept in the hand of a man who works in mergers and acquisitions.

Horkheimer and Adorno add a point that bears directly on the novel's form. The Sadean subject's apathy corresponds, they argue, to the bourgeois ideal of the self-controlled economic agent, whose passions have been disciplined into

calculation. Bateman is that agent without remainder. His narration evaluates a murder with the same instrument with which it evaluates a sauce: an instrumental rationality that has no internal resource for distinguishing the two.

2.3 Kant avec Sade: The Imperative to Enjoy

Jacques Lacan's "Kant avec Sade" (1963) sharpened the Frankfurt thesis. The Sadean maxim—that anyone may claim a right to enjoy any other's body without limit—is, Lacan observed, formally universalizable: it passes Kant's test. The categorical imperative and the libertine's maxim share a structure of unconditional command. Lacan further argued that the sadist does not occupy the position of the enjoying subject; he makes himself the *instrument* of the Other's will-to-enjoy, the executor of a demand that is not his own.

Slavoj Žižek (1989) generalized the insight to consumer society: the late-capitalist superego no longer prohibits but commands, and its command is "Enjoy!" Bateman's compulsions are therefore not freedom but obedience. His consumption is the fulfillment of an injunction issued by the market-Other, and his murders—the escalation of consumption past the point where any object can satisfy it—are that injunction pushed into the real. This explains the most striking affective fact of the novel, which is not the cruelty of the violence but its joylessness. Bateman enjoys on behalf of another, and the other is a system of exchange that cannot enjoy anything.

2.4 Transgression Without a Limit

Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) defines eroticism as assenting to life up to the point of death, and insists that transgression does not abolish the taboo but completes it: it suspends the prohibition without suppressing it, and draws its intensity from the prohibition's persistence. *La Part maudite* (1949) situates this sovereignty in a general economy of expenditure (*dépense*), the moment of loss without return that serves nothing and therefore cannot be captured by utility. Michel Foucault's "Préface à la transgression" (1963), written in homage to Bataille, describes transgression after the death of God as a flash that illuminates the limit it crosses, the two bound in a spiral.

American Psycho is the experimental refutation of this model under conditions of total commodification. Transgression requires a limit; Bateman's world has abolished the limit by abolishing the witness. No taboo is suspended because none is held; no limit is illuminated because nobody looks. The spiral collapses into a line, and the line becomes an escalation without illumination: each act more extreme than the last, none more revealing. The film's closing

voiceover—Bateman's observation that there are no more barriers to cross—is the epitaph of Foucault's spiral. Bataille's *dépense*, meanwhile, is reabsorbed into the restricted economy it was meant to exceed. Bateman's expenditure is literally an expense: his murders are financed, scheduled and cleaned up by paid service workers. It is sovereignty with a receipt.

Susan Sontag's "The Pornographic Imagination" (1967) had argued that pornography could be a serious literary mode, citing Bataille's *Histoire de l'œil* and Pauline Réage's *Histoire d'O* as works that explore the extremity of consciousness. Ellis's sexual and violent passages fail Sontag's test deliberately. They are written in the register of the instruction manual and the camera direction—positions, angles, durations—so that their effect is anaphrodisiac: not ecstasy but inventory. Where Sontag's exemplars sought the limit of consciousness, Ellis records its absence.

2.5 Murder as a Fine Art; Murder as a Consumer Good

Thomas De Quincey's "On Murder Considered as One of the Fine Arts" (1827) inaugurated the connoisseurship of murder: a gentleman's lecture to a society of aesthetes, evaluating killings as one evaluates paintings. The aristocratic lineage descends through André Gide's *acte gratuit* (Lafcadio's motiveless murder in *Les Caves du Vatican*, 1914), through Nathan Leopold and Richard Loeb's kidnapping and murder of fourteen-year-old Bobby Franks in 1924, staged as proof of their Nietzschean superiority, and Hitchcock's *Rope* (1948), to Thomas Harris's Hannibal Lecter, the cannibal of exquisite taste—Bach, Florence, haute cuisine—whose cinematic incarnation in Jonathan Demme's *The Silence of the Lambs* reached theaters in February 1991, a month before Ellis's novel reached bookstores.

The synchrony is instructive. American culture in 1991 possessed two cannibals: the aristocratic connoisseur and the bourgeois consumer. Lecter is De Quincey's heir, a killer whose violence is redeemed, in the audience's fascination, by style. Bateman is the negation of that lineage. His taste is relentlessly middlebrow; his philosophy is Donald Trump's *The Art of the Deal* (1987); his murders have no style because style has been entirely absorbed by his wardrobe. Mark Seltzer (1998) described the serial killer as the product of a "wound culture" fascinated by opened bodies and by the statistical person; Philip Jenkins (1994) documented how the 1980s serial-killer panic was constructed and inflated by institutional interests. Popular culture wanted the serial killer as an artist. Ellis supplied him as a consumer: his murders are mass-produced, branded, repeated and disposable—murder not as a fine art but as a consumer good.

2.6 Juliette in Armani

The chapter's argument can be condensed into an image. Bateman is Juliette dressed by the Italian couturiers whose labels he recites: the Sadean libertine reborn as a consumer, in whom what was for Sade a philosophical achievement—apathy against God, nature and law—has become a product feature. The sovereignty that Sade's heroes claimed by crossing every limit is, in Bateman's world, available off the rack. Chapter 12 will name the resulting formation *anaesthetic sovereignty*: a sovereignty that consists precisely in the impossibility of being affected, and which is therefore indistinguishable from the impossibility of acting.

3

The Blasé Metropolis and the Economy of Persons

From Veblen to Ballard, the sociology of money describes a single process that American Psycho *completes: the conversion of persons first into tokens of distinction, then into equivalents, then into images, and finally into nothing at all.*

3.1 Veblen: Predation in Pinstripes

Thorstein Veblen's *The Theory of the Leisure Class* (1899) supplies the novel's social grammar: conspicuous consumption, pecuniary emulation and, above all, *invidious comparison*, the ranking of persons by the visible evidence of their wealth. The business card scene is invidious comparison distilled to a single object. Less often noticed is Veblen's anthropological thesis. The leisure class, he argued, preserves the archaic traits of the predatory stage of culture—ferocity, self-seeking, clannishness—sublimated into pecuniary pursuits; *The Theory of Business Enterprise* (1904) distinguished the industrial employments, which make things, from the pecuniary employments, which acquire them, and located the predatory instinct in the latter. The trophies of the hunt become the trophies of the market.

Bateman reverses the sublimation. He works in mergers and acquisitions, the most purely pecuniary of employments, and he literally hunts: he stalks and kills, and in the novel he keeps parts of his victims' bodies in his apartment as trophies. Veblen's barbarian has not been civilized by finance; finance was the costume he wore while waiting.

3.2 Simmel: The Blasé Attitude and the Latent Aversion

Georg Simmel's *Philosophie des Geldes* (1900) argued that money, as the universal common denominator, reduces qualitative difference to quantitative difference and so hollows out the core of things; the means becomes the end. "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben" (1903) translated this into a psychology. The metropolis bombards the nerves; the metropolitan defends himself by intellectualizing his relations, and the result is the *blasé attitude*: an incapacity to react to new sensations with appropriate energy, an indifference not to things but to the distinctions between them. For the blasé person, Simmel writes, all things appear in an evenly flat and gray tone, none worthy of preference over another—the subjective mirror of a money economy in which all things float with equal specific gravity.

This is the most exact description of Ellis's narrative voice in the theoretical literature, written eighty-eight years before the novel. Bateman's narration assigns equal specific gravity to a murder and a menu; the flatness is not a stylistic affectation but the blasé attitude rendered as syntax. Simmel adds a second observation that is, if anything, more prophetic. Metropolitan *reserve*, he notes, conceals a latent aversion, a mutual strangeness and repulsion that can break into hatred at the moment of closer contact. Bateman's violence follows exactly this pattern: it erupts not in the street, where reserve holds, but at the moment of intimacy—in the bedroom, the apartment, the dinner for two.

3.3 Weber and Bell: The Ascetic Abdomen

Max Weber's *Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus* (1904–05) traced capitalism's origins to an inner-worldly asceticism that treated accumulation as a sign of election, and ended with a prophecy: the mechanized order would become a shell as hard as steel, and its last inhabitants might be described as "specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart." Bateman is both at once—the specialist in mergers whose work is spiritless, the sensualist whose pleasures are heartless—and so the fulfillment of Weber's prophecy in a single body.

Daniel Bell's *The Cultural Contradictions of Capitalism* (1976) identified the contradiction Weber's prophecy implied: capitalism requires ascetic discipline in production and hedonistic abandon in consumption. Bateman does not resolve the contradiction; he splits it across his body and his world. The asceticism migrates from the ledger to the abdomen—hundreds of crunches, the regimen of cleansers and masks, the dietary prohibitions—while the hedonism attaches to commodities and, beyond them, to bodies. Violence is the point at which the split fails, the return of the repressed contradiction. Weber also named the process of *Entzauberung*, the disenchantment of the world. The murders can be read as failed attempts at

re-enchantment: efforts to produce, through extremity, an experience the market cannot price. They fail because the market has already priced extremity.

3.4 Girard: Mimesis and the Crisis of Distinctions

René Girard's *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque* (1961) argued that desire is mimetic: we desire according to a mediator, wanting what our model wants. *La Violence et le sacré* (1972) traced the consequence. When the differences that structure a community collapse—what Girard calls the *crisis of distinctions*—rivals become doubles, mimetic rivalry escalates into general violence, and order is restored only through the scapegoat mechanism, the unanimous convergence of the community upon a marginal victim.

American Psycho is a Girardian laboratory. Desire is wholly mediated: Bateman wants the reservation at Dorsia because others cannot get it, wants Paul Owen's account and card because Owen has them. The crisis of distinctions is literalized in the novel's most pervasive motif: identical suits, haircuts and spectacles make the men indistinguishable, so that they constantly mistake one another—Girard's monstrous doubles reproduced as a running joke. The violence seeks its victims, as Girard predicts, at the margins: the homeless, sex workers, women, a child, animals, with immigrant workers receiving his racial abuse rather than his knife. Yet the mechanism fails, and its failure explains the seriality of the killing. A scapegoating requires a congregation—the unanimity of a community that experiences the victim's death as founding and sacred. Bateman's sacrifices have no witnesses and found nothing. The sacrifice never "takes," and so it must be repeated. Serial murder is, in Girardian terms, sacrifice without a congregation.

3.5 From Fetish to Reification to Simulation

Marx's account of commodity fetishism (*Capital* I, ch. 1, §4) describes social relations between people assuming the form of relations between things; Bateman's descriptions of people are descriptions of things. A less cited passage from *The Holy Family* (1845) is more exact still. The propertied class and the proletariat, Marx and Engels observe, present the same human self-estrangement; but the former feels at ease and confirmed in it, possessing in alienation the semblance of a human existence, while the latter feels annihilated. *American Psycho* records the moment at which the propertied class's ease fails—when the semblance of a human existence, inspected closely, discloses that there is no one inside it.

Georg Lukács's *Geschichte und Klassenbewußtsein* (1923) generalized fetishism into *reification*, the penetration of the commodity structure into consciousness itself, which assumes a "phantom objectivity" and adopts a contemplative stance toward

processes it no longer experiences as its own. Bateman watches his own acts as spectacle—most strikingly in the chapter "Chase, Manhattan," where the narration lurches into the third person (Chapter 8). Walter Benjamin's distinction between *Erfahrung* (integrated, transmissible experience) and *Erlebnis* (isolated shock), elaborated in "Über einige Motive bei Baudelaire" (1939), describes a subject who receives the world as a series of jolts that never accumulate into experience; Bateman's murders are *Erlebnisse* that leave no *Erfahrung* behind.

Guy Debord's *La Société du spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle as a social relation among people mediated by images, and as capital accumulated to the point at which it becomes image. Bateman's day is structured by the spectacle—the daily episode of *The Patty Winters Show*, whose absurd topics form the novel's chorus, and the videocassettes he rents compulsively, above all Brian De Palma's *Body Double* (1984) for its power-drill murder. The spectacle is both his screen and his script. Jean Baudrillard took the final step. *Le Système des objets* (1968) and *La Société de consommation* (1970) reconceived consumption as the manipulation of signs rather than the satisfaction of needs; *Simulacres et simulation* (1981) traced the successive phases of the image, from the reflection of a reality to the pure simulacrum that bears no relation to any reality whatever. Bateman's self-description—that there is an idea of a Patrick Bateman, an abstraction, but no real him—places the subject in the fourth phase. He is a simulacrum of a yuppie, preceded by his own model.

Fredric Jameson's "Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism" (1984; book 1991) codified the resulting condition: the waning of affect, the death of the subject, pastiche as "blank parody," a schizophrenic temporality of pure and unrelated presents, and the failure of "cognitive mapping," the incapacity of the individual to situate himself within the totality that determines him. The novel's relentless present tense, its absence of memory and history, and Bateman's knowledge of Manhattan as a constellation of restaurants and clubs without any grasp of the system they compose are, respectively, Jameson's temporality, his death of the subject and his failure of mapping. A decade before Jameson, J. G. Ballard's introduction to the French edition of *Crash* (1974) had named the "death of affect" among the gravest casualties of the century; his *Super-Cannes* (2000), in which corporate executives practice organized violence as therapy that sustains productivity, institutionalizes in a business park what Bateman does alone.

3.6 The Economy of Persons

The lineage converges on a single formation. Veblen describes persons ranked by display; Simmel, persons rendered equivalent by money; Girard, persons rendered doubles by mimesis; Marx and Lukács, persons rendered things; Debord and Baudrillard, persons rendered images and then simulacra; Jameson and Ballard, persons who no longer feel. Bateman is the point at which this *economy of persons* balances its books: every person has a price and therefore an equivalent, the blasé is the affect of equivalence, the spectacle is its medium, and the simulacrum is its product.

4

Narcissus at the End of History

Bateman is the last man of Fukuyama's post-historical order, a narcissist whose struggle for recognition is conducted in a world that has abolished the recognizer; his violence is the megalothymic residue of a history declared finished.

4.1 The Culture of Narcissism

Christopher Lasch's *The Culture of Narcissism* (1979) insisted that narcissism, properly understood, is not self-love but its opposite: a fragile, depleted self dependent for its coherence on the admiration of others, marked by shallow affect, terror of dependence, pseudo-insight into its own condition and fascination with celebrity. Drawing on Otto Kernberg (1975) and Heinz Kohut (1971), Lasch converted a clinical category into a sociological one: the narcissistic personality is the characteristic product of a bureaucratic, therapeutic and consumerist society. *The Minimal Self* (1984) extended the diagnosis to a survivalist contraction of the self to a defensive core. Tom Wolfe had already christened the 1970s the "Me Decade" (1976); the 1980s produced the yuppie, its institutional heir.

Bateman is Lasch's narcissist with the clinical vocabulary rendered literal. He depends on mirrors and on the envy of colleagues; his self-esteem fluctuates with the quality of a business card. Kohut's account of the idealized parental imago—the omnipotent figure with whom the fragile self seeks to merge—finds its object in Donald Trump, the novel's recurrent ego ideal, whose *The Art of the Deal* (1987) Bateman treats as scripture and whose imagined presence he pursues through Manhattan. The idealized imago of 1991 is a real-estate developer turned brand, a person whose name had become a product.

4.2 The Marketing Character and the Necrophilous Character

Erich Fromm's characterology provides the most precise humanist diagnosis. *Man for Himself* (1947) identified the *marketing orientation*: a character structure in which the person experiences himself as a commodity whose value is set by the market, an identity Fromm summarized, borrowing Pirandello's title, as "I am as you desire me." *The Anatomy of Human Destructiveness* (1973) described a second structure, the *necrophilous character*, drawn to the dead, the mechanical and the inorganic, to gadgets and technique, animated by the desire to convert the living into things. Fromm suspected that industrial society cultivated necrophilia as a mass orientation: the love of machines displacing the love of life.

Bateman fuses Fromm's two characters. His marketing self is assembled entirely from the desires of others; his necrophilia appears first in his relation to electronics—stereo components and televisions described with an erotic exactitude the text never extends to persons—and then in his relation to corpses. *To Have or to Be?* (1976) completed Fromm's analysis by distinguishing two modes of existence. In the *having* mode, I am what I possess; in the *being* mode, I am what I do and relate to. The novel's catalogs are the grammar of the having mode absolutized, and Bateman's declaration that he does not exist is its necessary conclusion: a self that consists entirely of possessions has no being left over.

The postwar sociology of character supplies the rest. David Riesman's *The Lonely Crowd* (1950) contrasted the inner-directed character, steered by an internal gyroscope, with the other-directed character, steered by a radar tuned to peers; Bateman is pure radar. C. Wright Mills's *White Collar* (1951) described the "personality market" in which white-collar workers sell their personalities along with their labor. Erving Goffman's *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1956) distinguished front stage from back stage; Bateman's back stage is the room where he kills. Arlie Russell Hochschild's *The Managed Heart* (1983), a feminist study of the commercialization of feeling, distinguished surface acting (displaying the required emotion) from deep acting (inducing it). Bateman's surface acting is flawless because there is no depth to act from.

4.3 Repressive Desublimation and Cynical Reason

Herbert Marcuse's *Eros and Civilization* (1955) analyzed the *performance principle* and the surplus repression it imposes; *One-Dimensional Man* (1964) added the concept of *repressive desublimation*, the liberalization of sexuality in forms that integrate it into domination rather than threatening it. Bateman's sexuality is the paradigm case: entirely unrepressed, pornographically explicit, and entirely administered—organized by camera angles, performance metrics and the codes of commercial video.

Peter Sloterdijk's *Kritik der zynischen Vernunft* (1983) named the ideological form of the period: *enlightened false consciousness*, in which subjects know perfectly well that their ideology is false and continue to act on it. Žižek (1989) condensed this into a formula: they know very well what they are doing, but still they are doing it. Bateman's celebrated dinner-party oration—an unprompted recitation of priorities from ending apartheid and slowing the arms race to sheltering the homeless, securing equal rights for women and restoring traditional values—is the purest specimen of cynical reason in American fiction. It is not hypocrisy, which presupposes belief in a norm one violates. It is a fully informed and fully inert inventory of norms, delivered by a man who kills the homeless and women, before an audience that nods. The norms are known. They simply weigh nothing.

4.4 The End of History and the Last Man

Hegel's *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) grounded self-consciousness in recognition: a self exists for itself only in being recognized by another self. The struggle for recognition produces master and slave, and with it the master's impasse—recognition from one he has subjugated is worthless. Alexandre Kojève's Paris lectures (1933–39; published 1947) read history as the working-out of this struggle, ending in a universal and homogeneous state in which recognition is mutual and the struggle ceases; post-historical humanity, Kojève speculated, might revert to a kind of animality. Francis Fukuyama's "The End of History?" (1989) and *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992) translated Kojève into the triumph of liberal democracy and market economy, and borrowed Nietzsche's figure of the *last man* from *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883–85)—the comfortable, blinking creature who has invented happiness and wants nothing more. Fukuyama's anxiety lay in *thymos*, the spirited desire for recognition. Where it seeks equal recognition (*isothymia*) it is satisfied by liberal democracy; where it seeks superiority (*megalothymia*) it is not, and Fukuyama worried that post-historical subjects might rebel against peace and prosperity out of sheer boredom.

American Psycho, published in the interval between Fukuyama's essay and his book, is the novel of that worry. Its chronology runs to the end of the 1980s, the decade that ended history. Bateman is the last man in whom megalothymia, denied every historical outlet—no war, no revolution, no frontier—curdles into murder. His struggle for recognition reproduces the Hegelian impasse at both ends. His peers, who might recognize him as an equal, cannot even tell him apart from others; his victims, whom he subjugates, recognize nothing but terror and then nothing at all. Kojève's post-historical animality returns, not as pastoral contentment, but as predation in a tailored suit.

4.5 Recognition Forgotten

Axel Honneth's *Kampf um Anerkennung* (1992) systematized Hegel into three spheres of recognition—love, legal rights and social esteem—each with a corresponding form of disrespect: bodily violation, the denial of rights, and denigration. Bateman inflicts all three, in descending order of visibility: he violates bodies; he treats the homeless as beings without rights; he denigrates through a constant stream of racist, antisemitic and homophobic contempt. Honneth's later Tanner Lectures, published as *Verdinglichung* (2005), redefined reification as *forgetfulness of recognition* (*Anerkennungsvergessenheit*): a primordial, affective engagement with others, prior to any cognition of them, is forgotten, and others are thereafter perceived as mere things.

This is the most exact philosophical description of Bateman's anaesthesia. He does not deny the personhood of others, which would require him to consider it; he has forgotten the antecedent engagement that would make personhood perceptible at all. His anaesthesia is not a judgment but an amnesia.

4.6 Narcissus and the Inverted Echo

Ovid's Narcissus (*Metamorphoses* III) spurns Echo, the nymph condemned to repeat only the last words of others, and wastes away before his reflection. *American Psycho* inverts the myth in its most persistent comic device. Bateman repeatedly tells the truth—that he is into murders and executions, that he is utterly insane, that he wants to kill—and the world returns, echo-like, only the acceptable words: *mergers and acquisitions*. Here the world is Echo, repeating back not what was said but what the market permits to be heard. Narcissus speaks, and the culture echoes the commodity. The confession is thereby defeated before it is made, a mechanism Chapter 8 traces to its juridical conclusion.

Part Two

II

The Text as Theory

5 The Itemized Subject: Catalog, Card, Routine, Review

6 A Critique of Pure Price: Dignity, Face, Fungibility

7 The Cannibal Ledger: Social Reproduction and the Political Economy of the Female Body

8 Crime Without Punishment: Dostoevsky, Becker, and the Undecidable Ledger

5

The Itemized Subject

Catalog, Card, Routine, Review

The novel's formal apparatus—the catalog, the business card, the morning routine and the music chapters—constructs what this dissertation calls the itemized subject*: a self whose identity is exhausted by an inventory of acquisitions and routines, and who therefore lacks the interior from which one could be affected.*

5.1 The Catalog as Form

The epic catalog—the catalogue of ships in *Iliad* II—totalizes a world by enumerating its forces. Whitman's catalogs in *Leaves of Grass* (1855) democratize the device: the self expands to include the world, and the poet declares that he is large and contains multitudes. Ellis inverts both. In Bateman's catalogs, the world of commodities contains a self that turns out to be empty; the enumeration does not expand the subject but replaces him. Umberto Eco's distinction between the *practical* list, finite and referential, and the *poetic* list, open-ended (*La vertigine della lista*, 2009), helps specify the effect: Bateman's lists are practical lists—itemizations of clothing, products, prices—that become poetic only through repetition, acquiring an *et cetera* that gestures not toward plenitude but toward exhaustion.

The catalog also inverts Hemingway's iceberg principle (*Death in the Afternoon*, 1932), in which omission implies depth: what the writer leaves out, if he knows it, strengthens what remains. Ellis includes everything in order to demonstrate that nothing lies beneath. The prose is assembled from found genres—menswear copy, restaurant guides, the consumer manual exemplified by *The Yuppie Handbook* (1984)—and its function is diagnostic. A self described entirely by its line items is not described at all; it is invoiced.

5.2 The Business Card: Pseudo-Individualization and the Narcissism of Minor Differences

The business card scene, present in the novel and elevated by Harron into the film's most quoted set piece, is a theory of identity compressed into stationery. Men in identical suits compare cards that differ only in stock, shade, typeface and watermark; Bateman, confronted with a superior card, sweats and panics. Adorno's "On Popular Music" (1941) furnishes the first concept: *standardization* and *pseudo-individualization*. The culture industry's products are interchangeable in structure, and their trivial variations—an ornament, a timbre—are inflated to conceal that standardization and to manufacture the experience of choice. The card is pseudo-individualization in a single object: identity reduced to the difference between two shades of off-white.

Freud supplies the second. In *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930), he named the *narcissism of minor differences*: hostility runs highest between those who are most alike, because their small distinctions bear the whole weight of their identity. The card scene is the purest literary illustration of Freud's concept, and it is lethal: the man with the superior card is the man Bateman kills. Veblen's invidious comparison and Girard's mimetic doubles converge here, and so does Dante's *Inferno* XVII. The card is a coat of arms, the heraldic purse of the usurer, legible where the face is not. Harron films it as a fetish in the strict Freudian sense (1927)—with reverent close-ups and swelling strings—the substitute object that disavows a lack. What the card disavows is the absence of a self.

5.3 The Morning Routine: Askesis, Human Capital, Ornamental Masculinity

The novel's "Morning" chapter and the film's opening voiceover present an exhaustive regimen of cleansers, scrubs, masks, conditioners and exercises. Foucault's late work on the *technologies of the self* (1982) and *Le Souci de soi* (1984) reconstructed ancient *askesis*: practices through which a subject constitutes himself as an ethical being. Bateman's askesis constitutes nothing. It is maintenance—the care of an asset rather than of a self. Foucault's lectures of 1978–79, *Naissance de la biopolitique*, had already analyzed the neoliberal subject as an *entrepreneur of himself*, investing in his own human capital in the sense theorized by Gary Becker's *Human Capital* (1964). The routine is capital maintenance, the management of depreciation.

It is also a gendered transposition. Susan Bordo's *Unbearable Weight* (1993) analyzed the disciplinary regimes—dieting, cosmetics, exercise—historically imposed on female bodies; *The Male Body* (1999) traced their extension to men through the advertising of the 1980s, when underwear campaigns first presented the male torso as an object to be looked at. Naomi Wolf's *The Beauty Myth* (1990)

described beauty culture as a political instrument for disciplining women. Bateman adopts the myth voluntarily, as a marker of status. Susan Faludi's *Stiffed* (1999) generalized the shift: American men, she argued, were moved from a utilitarian culture of production to an *ornamental culture* of display and celebrity, and suffered there a version of the objectification feminists had long described. Bateman is the ornamental man in his most extreme form—and, as Chapter 11 argues, the realization of Mary Wollstonecraft's 1792 critique of an education that trains its subjects for ornament rather than reason.

Harron's most iconic image condenses the argument. Bateman peels a translucent gel mask from his face while his voiceover explains that there is no real him. The face comes away as a product layer, revealing another surface beneath. Lacan's mirror stage (1949) described the ego as constituted in an image of bodily unity, an "armor" against the fantasy of the body in pieces. The routine is the daily maintenance of that armor, and Chapter 7 will show where the fragmentation it holds at bay is projected.

5.4 The Music Chapters: Blank Parody and Cultural Goodwill

Three chapters interrupt the narrative to deliver Bateman's criticism of Genesis, Whitney Houston and Huey Lewis and the News, written as pastiches of the album-by-album consumer review. They are the purest instance in fiction of what Jameson called *blank parody*: imitation without satirical intent and without a norm, funny precisely because they are not jokes. They are also, strikingly, the only places in the novel where Bateman sustains an opinion—and the opinions are the culture industry's own. Interior monologue has been replaced by the press release.

Pierre Bourdieu's *La Distinction* (1979) explains why the taste is what it is. Taste classifies the classifier; and the petit bourgeois relation to culture is marked by *cultural goodwill*, an earnest, anxious deference to legitimate culture without command of its codes. Bateman possesses abundant economic capital but displays the cultural goodwill of the petit bourgeois: his criticism parrots the evaluative vocabulary of record reviews, mistaking production values for meaning. Dwight Macdonald's "Masscult and Midcult" (1960) would have filed his taste under *midcult*, the kitsch that impersonates seriousness.

The chosen songs are themselves arguments. Houston's "Greatest Love of All" is an anthem of self-love, which Bateman praises as a universal moral message: narcissism, in Lasch's sense, elevated to ethics. Huey Lewis's "Hip to Be Square" proclaims conformity as the new rebellion, and the film sets Bateman's lecture on it immediately before he kills Paul Allen with an axe; Chapter 9 reads the scene as the collapse of Norman Mailer's opposition between Hip and Square. And the structure

of the chapters, as Chapter 2 observed, is that of the Sadean dissertation, the philosophical interlude between scenes, reduced to consumer advice.

5.5 "An Idea of a Patrick Bateman": The Self as Abstraction

The novel's most quoted passage—Bateman's account of himself as an idea, an abstraction, an entity, something illusory, behind which there is no real self—has been read as postmodern cliché. It is better read as a precise philosophical position with a long genealogy.

David Hume's *Treatise of Human Nature* (1739) denied that introspection discovers any self beyond "a bundle or collection of different perceptions." Bateman is Hume's bundle with the perceptions replaced by products. Heidegger's analysis of *das Man* in *Sein und Zeit* (1927, §27) described the everyday self as a "they-self" dispersed into anonymous averageness, in which *jeder ist der Andere und Keiner er selbst*—each is the other, and none is himself. The novel's endless misidentifications are this sentence dramatized.

Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990), published a year before the novel, theorized gender as the stylized repetition of acts that produces the identity it appears to express, and adopted Nietzsche's claim (*Genealogy of Morals* I.13) that there is no being behind the doing: the deed is everything. Bateman's routines are performativity in exactly this sense—they produce the masculine subject they seem to presuppose, and behind them stands no doer. But the comparison reveals a crucial difference. For Butler, the necessity of repetition opens a gap in which repetition can fail or be parodied, and from that gap subversion becomes possible. Bateman's repetitions never slip. His is *performativity without resignification*: a repetition so perfect that it forecloses the possibility of difference on which Butler's politics depends. Baudrillard's simulacrum names the result from the other side—a copy preceded by its model, an idea of a person circulating without a person.

The itemized subject is therefore the formal precondition of anaesthesia. A self that consists of its inventory has no interior in which an impression could register. It can acquire, display and discard; it cannot be moved.

6

A Critique of Pure Price

Dignity, Face, Fungibility

American Psycho *performs a Kantian critique in reverse: it deduces the conditions of possibility of a world in which nothing is above all price, and demonstrates that in such a world murder is not a transgression but a consistent conclusion.*

6.1 Price and Dignity

In the second section of the *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten* (1785), Kant writes that in the kingdom of ends everything has either a price or a dignity. Whatever has a price can be replaced by something else as its equivalent; whatever is raised above all price, and therefore admits of no equivalent, has a dignity. Kant subdivides price into *Marktpreis*, the market price of skill and diligence, and *Affektionspreis*, the fancy price of what pleases taste, wit and imagination, reserving *Würde*, inner worth, for morality and for humanity insofar as it is capable of morality.

The tripartite scheme illuminates the yuppie economy with surprising precision. Bateman's world is not dominated by market price, which concerns utility, but by fancy price: the premium on a watermark, a reservation, a label, a shade of bone. The middle term of Kant's scheme has swallowed the top term. Dignity has not been denied; it has been reclassified as taste. The consequences follow with deductive rigor. If everything has a price, everything has an equivalent. If persons have equivalents, they are replaceable. If they are replaceable, the destruction of one is a write-off rather than a crime. The novel's violence is not a departure from its world's logic but that logic carried to the end, and Kant's Formula of

Humanity—never to treat humanity merely as a means—has no purchase in a world that has no category for an end in itself.

6.2 Fungibility and Violability

Martha Nussbaum's "Objectification" (1995) disaggregated the concept into seven notions: instrumentality, denial of autonomy, inertness, *fungibility*, *violability*, ownership and denial of subjectivity. Rae Langton (*Sexual Solipsism*, 2009) added reduction to body, reduction to appearance and silencing. Applied to the novel, the taxonomy yields this dissertation's central analytic finding.

The men of *American Psycho* are radically fungible—interchangeable to the point that they cannot tell one another apart—but they are not, with one significant exception, violable. The women, the homeless and the racialized are fungible *and* violable. The homeless are, in addition, socially invisible: their violation leaves no trace. Fungibility, in other words, is universal; violability is distributed by gender, class and race. The text's two dominant registers correspond exactly to this asymmetry. The comic register satirizes male fungibility—the misidentifications, the identical suits, the card scene. The horror register enacts female and subaltern violability. The two registers are not tonal inconsistency but two faces of a single structure: in a world of universal equivalence, everyone is replaceable, but only some may be destroyed.

The exception confirms the rule. Paul Owen—Paul Allen in the film—is the one peer Bateman kills, and he is killed because his superior card, apartment and account threaten to differentiate him; violence among equals is reserved for the man who has escaped fungibility. Langton's *sexual solipsism* names Bateman's double error: he treats things as persons, lavishing on stereo components the attentive description he never grants to people, and persons as things.

6.3 Everyone Is the Other: The Economy of Misrecognition

The misrecognitions form a dense network. Paul Owen takes Bateman for Marcus Halberstam, and Bateman later adopts Halberstam's identity as an alibi; Harold Carnes, receiving the confession, takes Bateman for someone named Davis; at dinners and clubs the men address one another by the wrong names without consequence. Misrecognition is not an incident in this world but its social bond. Faces have ceased to function as signs of singularity; identity is carried by insignia.

The classical comedy of mistaken identity, from Plautus's *Menaechmi* to Shakespeare's *Comedy of Errors*, resolves in recognition—what Aristotle's *Poetics* calls *anagnorisis*, the passage from ignorance to knowledge. *American Psycho* is constructed so that anagnorisis is structurally impossible. Nobody is ever

recognized, least of all by the reader, who cannot know whether the confession is true. The novel is thus a comedy of errors that never resolves and a tragedy without a recognition scene.

6.4 The Face: Levinas and the Peeled Mask

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) located the origin of ethics in the face (*visage*) of the Other: an epiphany of infinity that exceeds every attempt to comprehend or possess it, and whose first expression is a command—you shall not commit murder. Murder, Levinas argues, is the only power one has over the face, and it fails: one can kill the Other but cannot possess the Other's alterity. Levinas opposed this ethics of infinity to *totality*, an ontology that reduces the other to the same.

Bateman's world is totality without remainder: everything is comprehended under the single category of price. The face is precisely what price cannot comprehend, and the novel's most emblematic attack is aimed at the face: Bateman blinds the homeless man Al with a knife, as though to silence the organs through which the face commands. The film's version of that attack is briefer, and it relocates the assault on the face to the peeled mask. Levinas emphasized the face's nakedness and destitution, its exposure. Bateman's world has dressed the face—tanned, moisturized, framed in designer spectacles—and so muted its command; Harron's image of the peeled gel mask shows a face that comes off like packaging.

The closing image of Foucault's *Les Mots et les choses* (1966) proposed that "man" is a recent invention, perhaps nearing its end, to be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. The novel shows the erasure in progress: the face that humanism drew, washing out under a tide of commodities.

6.5 The Banality of Surface: Arendt and the Unnarrated *Who*

Hannah Arendt's *Eichmann in Jerusalem* (1963) diagnosed in Eichmann not monstrous depth but thoughtlessness: an inability to think from the standpoint of another, expressed in a speech made of clichés and bureaucratic formulas. Her letter to Gershom Scholem that year sharpened the claim: evil is never radical, only extreme; it has neither depth nor any demonic dimension, and it can lay waste the world precisely because it spreads like *a fungus on the surface*. The difference of historical magnitude between a functionary of genocide and a fictional killer is absolute, and the comparison concerns only the *form* of evil. In that respect, Ellis's poetics of surface is the novelistic form of Arendt's ontology. Mailer's complaint that the novel refuses Bateman an interior misreads its thesis: the absence of depth is the point. *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) adds that domination proceeds by rendering human beings *superfluous*; the homeless in Bateman's economy are superfluous before he touches them.

The Human Condition (1958) supplies the distinction on which this dissertation's constructive argument rests. Action and speech disclose *who* someone is, as distinct from *what* someone is—the qualities, talents and shortcomings one shares with others. The *who* appears only to others and is often grasped only in the story told about a life. Adriana Cavarero (*Tu che mi guardi, tu che mi racconti*, 1997; trans. *Relating Narratives*, 2000) developed this into an ethics of the *narratable self*: each unique existent desires her story, which only another can tell. Bateman's narration consists exclusively of *whats*—garments, prices, body types—and his violence reduces others to the condition his description had already assigned them. The emblem is the sex worker whom he renames "Christie." Her own name is never known. She enters the text as a *what* he invented, and the *who* she was remains unnarrated. Chapter 12 builds its alternative humanism on precisely this absence.

6.6 Man2 and the Pseudo-Humanist: Wynter, Césaire, Conrad

Sylvia Wynter's "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom" (2003) traces the West's successive descriptive statements of the human: Man1, the political subject of the Renaissance state, and Man2, the economic subject of the nineteenth century onward, each overrepresenting a particular genre of the human as the human as such. Man2's others are the *dysselected*—the jobless, the homeless, the poor, the racialized—marked as failures by economic and pseudo-biological criteria. Bateman is Man2 in pure form, and his victims are Wynter's dysselected. When he lectures the homeless man Al about getting a job and then attacks him with a knife (in the novel, blinding him), he pronounces homo oeconomicus's verdict on those it has excluded from the human.

Aimé Césaire's *Discours sur le colonialisme* (1950) described the very distinguished, very humanistic, very Christian bourgeois of the twentieth century who carries a Hitler within him, and named the humanism that tolerated colonial atrocity a *pseudo-humanism*, narrow, fragmentary and racist. Bateman's humanitarian oration followed by murder is Césaire's figure exposed. Conrad had dramatized the same structure in *Heart of Darkness* (1899), in which Kurtz's eloquent report for the International Society for the Suppression of Savage Customs ends in a scrawled postscript: "Exterminate all the brutes!" Bateman's oration is the report; the novel is the postscript.

6.7 The Failed Empirical Metaphysics

The chapter's most speculative claim can now be stated. Bateman's dismemberments are not only expressions of rage or of pleasure; they are a *search*. He opens bodies as though to find, inside them, what the market cannot price—the inner worth Kant called dignity, the interiority Bateman knows himself to lack. The search is conducted empirically, with blades, drills and cameras, and it is the degraded heir of the humanist anatomical gaze: Andreas Vesalius's *De humani corporis fabrica* (1543) opened the body to know man; Rembrandt's *Anatomy Lesson of Dr. Nicolaes Tulp* (1632) staged dissection as civic knowledge.

The search finds only matter, and this confirms its premise: if dignity existed, it would be found; it is not found; therefore there is only price. The metaphysics fails by succeeding. Its error is what Gilbert Ryle (*The Concept of Mind*, 1949) would call a category mistake, committed with corpses. Kant had placed dignity beyond experience precisely so that no anatomy could refute it. Bateman, who knows only what can be seen, itemized and owned, cannot follow him there; and the vacancy he discovers inside others is the mirror of the vacancy he reports inside himself.

7

The Cannibal Ledger

Social Reproduction and the Political Economy of the Female Body

Bateman's violence is not randomly distributed: it falls on the reproductive, expropriated, natural and political substrates on which the economy that produced him depends, so that his cannibalism literalizes what Nancy Fraser has called cannibal capitalism.

7.1 The Traffic in Women and the Homosocial Circuit

Claude Lévi-Strauss's *Les Structures élémentaires de la parenté* (1949) located the origin of social order in the exchange of women between groups of men. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975) turned the observation into a critique: in the *sex/gender system*, women function as conduits of relations among men, and their exchange founds a social contract to which they are not party. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) showed how English literature routes male homosocial desire through erotic triangles in which a woman mediates the bond between two men, and how homophobia polices the continuum between homosocial and homosexual desire.

The novel's erotic arrangements are diagrammatically Rubinian. Courtney, engaged to Luis Carruthers, is Bateman's lover; Evelyn is Bateman's fiancée; women circulate among the men as tokens of status. The triangle is exposed by Luis, whose desire for Bateman completes the circuit Sedgwick describes. In the restroom scene, present in novel and film alike, Bateman's attempt to strangle Luis is received by Luis as an erotic overture, and Bateman, overcome by what Sedgwick in *Epistemology of the Closet* (1990) would call homosexual panic, cannot complete the act. The one man Bateman cannot kill is the one who openly desires him. Women are the currency, men the market, and homophobia the market's regulator.

7.2 Primitive Accumulation and the Female Body

Marx described the "so-called primitive accumulation" (*Capital* I, part 8) as the violent separation of producers from their means of production, through which capital came into the world dripping with blood and dirt from every pore. Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) demonstrated that this process was also an enclosure of women's bodies: the European witch-hunts disciplined women's reproductive capacity, constituted the sexual division of labor and turned the body into the first machine. For Federici, capital's founding violence against women is not a historical stage but a recurrent operation, renewed at each phase of accumulation; David Harvey's *The New Imperialism* (2003) named the neoliberal form of this recurrence *accumulation by dispossession*.

Bateman, whose profession is acquisition, performs primitive accumulation inside finance capital. The female body is treated as the last commons, to be enclosed, fragmented and appropriated by a man whose working life consists of absorbing other enterprises.

7.3 The Bateman Quadrilateral

Nancy Fraser's "Behind Marx's Hidden Abode" (2014) argued that capitalism depends on "background conditions" that it does not produce and cannot price: social reproduction, nature and public power. Subsequent work added the expropriation of racialized populations (Fraser and Jaeggi 2018), and *Cannibal Capitalism* (2022) synthesized the four into a single thesis: capitalism devours the conditions of its own possibility. The victimology of *American Psycho* maps onto Fraser's scheme with a completeness that can hardly be coincidental, though it was certainly not intended. This dissertation calls the mapping the *Bateman quadrilateral*.

Fraser's background condition	Its form in American Psycho	Mode of devouring
Social repr oduction	Women; sex workers; the secretary Jean; the emotional labor of fiancées and hostesses; a small boy Bateman murders at the zoo (novel)	Consumption of care, then destruction of the carer
Expropriat ed populati ons	The homeless man Al; immigrant dry cleaners; a running stream of racial contempt	Contempt for the "jobless," mutilation, erasure
Nature	The homeless man's dog; an ATM that instructs Bateman to feed it a stray cat; a live rat he uses to torture a woman (novel)	Animals as inputs to the machine
Public power	Detective Kimball; a lawyer's answering machine; Reagan's televised Iran–Contra statements	The polity reduced to a screen and a recording

The ATM episode deserves emphasis because it renders the scheme as allegory. A cash machine, the automaton of finance, demands to be fed a living animal: capital, quite literally, asks for nature as an input. The fourth corner is completed by the novel's ending, in which the confession reaches only a machine and the President appears only on television. The polity has not been destroyed; it has been hollowed into media.

7.4 The Absent Referent and the Modest Proposal

Carol J. Adams's *The Sexual Politics of Meat* (1990) theorized the *absent referent*: through butchering, the animal is made absent as an animal so that meat can exist, and the same structure of objectification, fragmentation and consumption organizes cultural representations of women, from advertising to pornography. Published a year before *American Psycho*, Adams's book reads as its theoretical gloss. Bateman enacts the cycle on women with literal exactness: in the novel he kills women, dismembers their bodies and tries to cook and eat one of them, and Harron's title sequence announces the equivalence at once: red drops fall across a white field, blades slice, and the camera reveals sauce, a plated dish, a restaurant. Plating and wounding are introduced as one gesture.

The novel's most notorious chapter title, "Tries to Cook and Eat Girl," turns on its first verb. *Tries* records a failure: consumption is not completed. The referent does not wholly disappear; something of the person remains indigestible. This residue will become the first term of the *feminist remainder* in Chapter 12.

Jonathan Swift's *A Modest Proposal* (1729) is the originary satire of economic cannibalism. Its projector proposes, with calm arithmetic, that the infants of the Irish poor be sold as food for the wealthy, noting that the landlords, who have already devoured most of the parents, seem to have the best title to the children. Satire works here by literalism, turning a metaphor of exploitation into policy in the voice of economic reason. Bateman is Swift's projector without a proposal: he does not argue, he acts. The satire has migrated from argument to practice, and the ironic gap between Swift and his projector survives in Ellis only as the reader's revulsion.

7.5 Armor and Flood: Theweleit, Klein, Kristeva

Klaus Theweleit's *Männerphantasien* (1977–78) reconstructed the fantasy life of the Freikorps "soldier males" of Weimar Germany: their dread of dissolution, figured as flood and fluid; their *Körperpanzer*, the body-armor of drill and discipline; and their division of women into the "white" (nurse, mother, sister—idealized, desexualized, spared) and the "red" (proletarian, sexual, threatening—to be reduced to a bloody mass). Barbara Ehrenreich's foreword to the English translation (1987) insisted that these men were not aberrations but intensified versions of ordinary masculinity. Ehrenreich's own *The Hearts of Men* (1983) and *Fear of Falling* (1989)—the latter a portrait of the professional-managerial class whose apotheosis was the yuppie—provide the sociological bridge from Weimar to Wall Street.

The film's women divide along Theweleit's line with startling clarity: Jean, the devoted secretary, is spared; Christie, the sex worker, is killed: Bateman drops a running chainsaw down a stairwell onto her as she flees. Bateman's armored body is maintained daily; his horror of fluids is legible in his hygiene and in the novel's anxieties about contagion, which Susan Sontag's *AIDS and Its Metaphors* (1989) situates within a culture of invasion and pollution.

Melanie Klein's "Notes on Some Schizoid Mechanisms" (1946) described the *paranoid-schizoid position*, in which the infant splits its world into idealized and persecutory part-objects and projects intolerable states into others. Lacan's mirror-ego, armored against the fantasy of the *corps morcelé*, completes the account: the fragmentation that threatens Bateman's imaginary unity is projected onto the bodies of victims. He dismembers others in order to remain whole. Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) defined the *abject* as what disturbs identity, system and order, with the corpse as its extreme; Barbara Creed (1993) traced its gendering in horror cinema as the monstrous-feminine. Bateman oscillates between rituals of purification by morning and the production of abjection by night—a ritual economy without a sacred, purifying a self that does not exist against a contamination it manufactures.

7.6 The Frenzy of the Visible

Linda Williams's *Hard Core* (1989) identified pornography's founding drive as the *frenzy of the visible*: the attempt to make the truth of pleasure visible, which culminates in the "money shot," a visible male proof displacing an invisible female pleasure. Bateman's sexual encounters are staged for the camera—he films, directs positions, attends to the mirror—and his violence pushes the frenzy of the visible past the skin. Evisceration is the money shot extended into the interior: the effort to see what cannot be seen, to make the inside yield its truth. It yields only matter, which links the pornographic drive directly to the failed empirical metaphysics of Chapter 6. That the industry's term for its climactic image is the *money shot*, in a novel about money, is a coincidence the novel does not need to remark.

7.7 The Service Infrastructure of Impunity

Deborah Cameron and Elizabeth Frazer's *The Lust to Kill* (1987) argued that sexual murder is a cultural product: the killer pursues masculine transcendence, in Beauvoir's sense, through the destruction of others, and culture romanticizes him as an existential outsider, from Colin Wilson's *The Outsider* (1956) to Mailer. Jane Caputi's *The Age of Sex Crime* (1987) dated the modern era of sexual murder to Jack the Ripper and read it as a form of terror that maintains male dominance; Jill Radford and Diana E. H. Russell's *Femicide* (1992) gave the phenomenon its political name.

Evelyn Nakano Glenn's "From Servitude to Service Work" (1992) traced the racial division of paid reproductive labor in the United States. *American Psycho* shows that labor as the infrastructure of impunity. Dry cleaners launder the bloodied sheets; a realtor sanitizes Owen's apartment to protect its sale; doormen, secretaries and service staff keep the sovereign's life running. The reproductive class cleans up after the producing class, and the producing class directs its violence precisely at the reproductive class—a structure this dissertation calls *violence against reproduction*.

7.8 The Ledger

The *cannibal ledger* is the double-entry book of anaesthetic sovereignty. On one side stand the assets of the sovereign subject: suits, reservations, accounts, a body maintained like capital. On the other stand the debits, drawn on women's bodies, on the homeless, on animals and on a hollowed polity. The emblematic entry is the woman Bateman renames "Christie": a body entered in the ledger under a name not her own.

8

Crime Without Punishment

Dostoevsky, Becker, and the Undecidable Ledger

The undecidability of Bateman's murders is the formal transcription of class impunity: in a world where the killing of the dispossessed leaves no institutional trace, the difference between act and fantasy is socially inoperative, and the reader who asks whether the murders "really happened" is placed in the position of the system that has already decided it does not matter.

8.1 Two Crimes and Punishments

Dostoevsky's *Crime and Punishment* (1866) is built on a theory, a crime, an investigation, a confession and a redemption. Raskolnikov's article on the "extraordinary man" licenses transgression; with an axe he kills the pawnbroker Alyona Ivanovna, a usurer, and then her half-sister Lizaveta, who walks in on the crime; Porfiry Petrovich conducts a psychological siege; Raskolnikov confesses first to Sonya Marmeladova, who has entered prostitution to support her family and who becomes the novel's moral center; he confesses publicly, goes to Siberia, and the epilogue intimates resurrection.

American Psycho inverts every term. There is no theory, only *The Art of the Deal*. Raskolnikov kills a usurer, and then an innocent woman who sees him; Bateman is the usurer, and he kills the dispossessed. Only the weapon survives the translation: Raskolnikov's axe is the one Bateman uses on Paul Owen. Detective Kimball, Porfiry's heir, talks about restaurants and films and never lays psychological siege. The decisive inversion concerns Sonya. The figure through whom Dostoevsky routes confession and grace is a sex worker; Ellis's sex workers are Bateman's victims. The moral center of the Russian novel is the woman the American novel

kills. Bateman's confession goes not to her but to a lawyer's answering machine, and it is laughed away. There is no Siberia and no resurrection.

A second *Crime and Punishment* shadows the first. Gary Becker's "Crime and Punishment: An Economic Approach" (1968), whose title echoes Dostoevsky's, modeled the offender as a rational agent who commits a crime when its expected utility exceeds that of alternatives, the expected penalty being the product of the probability of conviction and the severity of punishment. Optimal enforcement, on this view, minimizes social loss rather than crime. Foucault's lecture of 21 March 1979 (*Naissance de la biopolitique*) drew the anthropological consequence: neoliberal penality treats the criminal not as a moral or psychological type but as homo oeconomicus, anyone who invests in an action, expects a profit and accepts the risk of a loss.

Bateman is Becker's limit case. For a man of his class, the probability of conviction approaches zero, and the Beckerian calculus then places no bound on crime: crime becomes a purchase priced at nothing. The novel unfolds in the space between the two *Crime and Punishments*—the theological, which requires confession and grace, and the economic, which requires only price—and it shows what happens when the second has entirely displaced the first. Bateman's acts are not even crimes in the economic sense. They are costless consumption.

8.2 The Narratology of Undecidability

Wayne Booth's *The Rhetoric of Fiction* (1961) defined the unreliable narrator as one whose norms diverge from the implied author's. James Phelan's *Living to Tell About It* (2005) distinguished misreporting, misreading and misregarding, the last an error of evaluation. Bateman's unreliability is primarily of the third kind: his evaluations are grotesque while his reports, in their brand-name exactitude, seem hyper-reliable. But the text also plants signals of misreporting. In "Chase, Manhattan," during an implausible action sequence of exploding police cars and casual killings, the narration abruptly shifts into the third person and then returns to the first—a rupture of narrative voice in which Bateman appears to watch himself as the hero of an action film. The apartment in which he has stored bodies is later found immaculate and on the market, its realtor coolly advising him to leave. Harold Carnes reports having dined with the supposedly murdered Owen in London. An automated teller issues instructions.

Criticism has divided accordingly into the *realist* reading (the murders happened and the system absorbed them), the *fantasist* reading (they are delusions) and the *undecidable* reading (the text forbids determination). Ellis has consistently declined to adjudicate. Harron has said that she regretted the extent to which the

film's ambiguity was taken as a "dream" resolution, since she intended it to concern the system's indifference rather than the reality of the acts. She has also described shooting Willem Dafoe's scenes as Kimball in several versions—as a detective who believes Bateman guilty, one who believes him innocent, and one who is undecided—and intercutting them, so that the state's knowledge itself becomes undecidable in the edit.

8.3 Undecidability as Impunity

This dissertation's claim is that the undecidability is not an epistemological puzzle but the formal transcription of a social fact. When the killing of the homeless and of sex workers produces no institutional trace—no investigation that anyone pursues, no witness who is believed, no apartment that is not cleaned for sale—the difference between murder and fantasy ceases to be socially operative. The question "did it really happen?" is one the system has already answered: it does not matter.

The reader who asks the question is thereby placed in the system's position: that of a hearer for whom the reality of the victims depends on evidence that the system ensures will never exist. The novel's formal achievement is to make the reader experience this position as an itch, a need to know that cannot be satisfied. Chapter 12 will argue that the ethical response is to refuse the system's indifference by insisting that the victims matter even where the murders remain undecidable. In fiction, the dead are exactly as real as the text makes them, and the text makes them real enough to scream.

8.4 Credibility Immunity

Miranda Fricker's *Epistemic Injustice* (2007) distinguished *testimonial injustice*, in which identity prejudice deflates a speaker's credibility, from *hermeneutical injustice*, in which a gap in shared interpretive resources disadvantages someone in making sense of their own experience. José Medina (*The Epistemology of Resistance*, 2013) showed that credibility *excess* can also be unjust. This dissertation proposes a further category, *credibility immunity*: the condition in which a privileged speaker's self-incriminating testimony is disbelieved because his social identity is, in the hearer's prejudice, incompatible with criminality.

Carnes cannot believe the confession because he regards Bateman as a dull, timid sycophant—a type who could not kill anyone. The identity prejudice that would generate a credibility deficit for a homeless confessant generates immunity for Bateman. Credibility immunity is therefore the structural twin of testimonial injustice: the same prejudice that silences the victims shields the killer. Hermeneutical injustice completes the picture, since the sex workers'

disappearances fall into a gap in the shared concepts through which anyone might register them as crimes.

The gendered asymmetry is clarified by a text Harron herself later adapted. Margaret Atwood's *Alias Grace* (1996)—directed by Harron as a television series in 2017, from Sarah Polley's script—concerns Grace Marks, an Irish servant convicted in 1843 of complicity in murder, whose guilt the narrative leaves undecidable while subjecting her testimony to exhaustive psychiatric and journalistic scrutiny. The poor woman whose guilt is uncertain is believed guilty; the rich man who confesses is believed innocent. That the same director staged both undecidabilities is the most precise index of her career-long concern with the gendering of credibility.

8.5 Immunitas: The Confession That Cannot Pay

Roberto Esposito's *Communitas* (1998) and *Immunitas* (2002) derive community from the *munus*, the obligation, gift or debt that members owe one another, and define immunity as exemption from it. The immunitary paradigm protects life by negating it, and in its intensified form turns autoimmune. Bateman is immune in every register at once: juridically (impunity), biologically (the hygienic regimen, the dread of contagion), affectively (anaesthesia) and communally (exemption from reciprocity). His confession is an attempt to pay into the *munus*—to become indebted, and so to belong—and it is refused, because his immunity is absolute. His closing account of a constant pain he wishes others to share reads, in Esposito's terms, as autoimmunity: the immune system turned against the self it was meant to protect.

Walter Benjamin's fragment "Kapitalismus als Religion" (1921) described capitalism as a cult without dogma, of permanent duration, and the first cult that creates guilt rather than atonement; the German *Schuld* means both guilt and debt, and Nietzsche's *Genealogy of Morals* (II.4) had already derived the moral concept from the commercial one. Bateman's confession is a defaulted debt in a cult without atonement. The Scrovegni Chapel of Chapter 1 marks the contrast: the medieval economy of sin could convert usurious guilt into art and grace; Bateman's economy has no chapel. Its confessional is an answering machine—address without reception, the technical form of a world in which no one is listening.

8.6 Homo Sacer and the Sovereign

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) revived a figure of archaic Roman law: one who may be killed but not sacrificed, and whose killing does not count as homicide. Following Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as he who decides on the exception (*Politische Theologie*, 1922), Agamben argued that sovereign and homo sacer are symmetrical figures, both outside the law. Bateman's victims are homines sacri: killable without the killing registering. Bateman occupies the sovereign position, but no one decided it; the exception is produced not by decision but by indifference. Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) defined sovereignty as the power to dictate who may live and who must die; the novel shows that power exercised by a private man with a platinum card. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) analyzed the differential distribution of *grievability*: the frames that determine which lives count as lives. Bateman's narration is a frame of ungrievability, and the reader's capacity to grieve within it is the novel's test.

8.7 The President's Heart and the Facts

Novel and film end in Harry's bar, where the men watch Reagan's televised statements on the Iran–Contra affair and wonder aloud how he can lie so smoothly. The most notorious of those statements, the address of 4 March 1987, turned on a chiasmus: "A few months ago I told the American people I did not trade arms for hostages. My heart and my best intentions still tell me that's true, but the facts and the evidence tell me it is not." Bateman's situation is the inverse. His heart, so to speak, says guilty, and the available "facts" say innocent. In both cases, the consequences are nil. The juxtaposition sets the unbelieved private confession against the absorbed public one and identifies the polity—the fourth corner of the Bateman quadrilateral—as the place where truth has ceased to entail consequence.

8.8 Crime as Purchase

The chapter's argument condenses into three formulas. Crime becomes a purchase when punishment is a price and the price is zero. Confession becomes a default when guilt is a debt in a cult without atonement. Undecidability becomes impunity when the institutions that would decide have no interest in the dead.

Part Three

III

Controversy and Counter-Adaptation

9 Must We Burn Bateman? The 1990–91 Controversy and the Feminist Sex Wars

10 The Gaze Returned: Harron and Turner's Counter-Adaptation

9

Must We Burn Bateman?

The 1990–91 Controversy and the Feminist Sex Wars

The controversy over American Psycho *restaged the feminist sex wars of the 1980s; this chapter argues that the novel's defenders were right about its illocutionary force and its critics right to fear its perlocutionary afterlife, and proposes Simone de Beauvoir's reading of Sade as a third position that neither burns nor canonizes.*

9.1 The Scandal as a Reading Practice

The most consequential judgments of the novel were made before it was published, on the basis of excerpts. The scandal was thus, among other things, a reading practice: the extraction of the passages in which Bateman tortures, mutilates and kills women, often during or after sex, from the architecture of repetition, flatness and comedy in which they were embedded. That practice mirrored, with unintended exactness, the fragmentation the novel performs on bodies—Adams's cycle of objectification and fragmentation, applied to a text. Ellis received death threats. The Los Angeles chapter of NOW, under Tammy Bruce, called for a boycott of Vintage and its parent house; other feminists, including the novelist Fay Weldon, defended the book as a moral indictment. The division ran through feminism, not between feminists and their opponents, and it reproduced the fault line of the preceding decade.

9.2 The Sex Wars

The anti-pornography position was articulated in Andrea Dworkin's *Pornography: Men Possessing Women* (1981) and Catharine MacKinnon's *Feminism Unmodified* (1987) and *Toward a Feminist Theory of the State* (1989): pornography is not a representation of subordination but a practice of it, which sexualizes inequality and constructs what sex means. Dworkin and MacKinnon drafted civil-rights ordinances permitting suits against traffickers in pornography; the Indianapolis version was struck down in *American Booksellers Association v. Hudnut* (7th Cir. 1985), in an opinion that accepted the premise that pornography shapes attitudes while holding that this demonstrated its power as speech. Women Against Pornography had organized from 1979.

The opposing position, variously called sex-radical, pro-sex or anti-censorship, was articulated in Ellen Willis's "Feminism, Moralism, and Pornography" (1979), at the 1982 Barnard Conference on Sexuality, in the resulting volume *Pleasure and Danger* (ed. Carole Vance, 1984)—which included Gayle Rubin's "Thinking Sex"—by the Feminist Anti-Censorship Taskforce (1984), and later in Nadine Strossen's *Defending Pornography* (1995). Its claims were that censorship historically harms women and sexual minorities, that sexual representation is a terrain of women's own agency, and that the state is an unreliable ally. The NOW boycott inherited the first framework, treating the novel as a manual of misogynist violence; its defenders inherited the second, invoking satire and artistic freedom.

9.3 Locution, Illocution, Perlocution

MacKinnon's *Only Words* (1993) drew on J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) to argue that pornography is not merely speech about subordination but an act of subordination. Austin distinguished the *locutionary* act (saying something meaningful), the *illocutionary* act (what is done in saying it—warning, promising, ordering) and the *perlocutionary* act (what is brought about by saying it—persuading, frightening, arousing). Rae Langton's "Speech Acts and Unspeakable Acts" (1993) formalized MacKinnon's claim: pornography can have the illocutionary force of subordinating and silencing, provided its speaker has authority in the relevant domain.

The framework clarifies what the 1991 debate could not. The illocutionary force of *American Psycho* is determined by its form, and its form is engineered against pornographic uptake. Its sexual and violent passages are written in a flat, inventorial register, embedded in deadening repetition and counterpointed by a comedy of male fungibility; they are designed to fail as arousal and to succeed as nausea. On the question of illocution, the defenders were right. But perlocution is

not governed by the speaker. A text's effects can exceed its illocutionary design, and the novel's twenty-first-century afterlife, in which its protagonist circulates as an aspirational template (see the Coda), demonstrates that uptake can be captured by readers the form was built to repel. On the question of perlocution, the critics' anxiety was prescient, even if their remedy was not. Both sides erred in assuming that the question could be settled by the text alone.

9.4 Must We Burn Sade?

Simone de Beauvoir's "Faut-il brûler Sade?" (*Les Temps modernes*, 1951–52; collected in *Privilèges*, 1955) offers the model this dissertation adopts. Beauvoir refused both the Surrealists' canonization of Sade and the censor's fire. Sade mattered, she argued, because he posed with unprecedented force the problem of the relation between one human being and another; his cruelty was inseparable from his solitude and from his failure to achieve communication; and the value of his work lay in its power to disturb—to oblige readers to reconsider what reciprocity requires.

Applied to Ellis, Beauvoir's position yields a third feminist response, distinct from both boycott and defense. *American Psycho* should be read as a document of the impossibility of reciprocity in a commodified world: an exhibit of the solitude that makes cruelty not only possible but frictionless. Beauvoir's own ethics, set out in *Pour une morale de l'ambiguïté* (1947), held that to will oneself free is to will others free. Bateman wills no one free, including himself. Must we burn Bateman? No. But neither may we merely laugh with him. We must read him as Beauvoir read Sade: lucidly, as a disturbance that teaches.

9.5 Millett, Mailer, and the Collapse of the Hip and the Square

Kate Millett's *Sexual Politics* (1970) founded feminist literary criticism as political critique, reading Lawrence, Miller, Mailer and Genet for the sexual politics their fictions enact. Her treatment of Mailer's *An American Dream* (1965)—in which Stephen Rojack murders his wife and emerges renewed—read the novel as a fantasy of male power achieved through violence against women. Mailer had earlier written the founding document of the American romance of the psychopath. "The White Negro" (*Dissent*, 1957) divided postwar America into the Hip and the Square, celebrated the psychopath as an existential rebel against conformity, and grounded its romance in a racial primitivism that James Baldwin dismantled in "The Black Boy Looks at the White Boy" (1961). Mailer's violence was not only literary: in 1960 he stabbed his second wife, Adele Morales, and later pleaded guilty to assault—a fact that marks how far the literary romance of male violence was from being "only words."

A single trajectory now becomes visible. In 1957, the psychopath is Hip, the outsider in revolt against the Square. In 1986, Huey Lewis and the News proclaim that it is hip to be square. In 1991, the psychopath is the Square himself—the conformist, the yuppie, the most inside of insiders—and Mailer, reviewing the novel in *Vanity Fair*, complains that it denies its killer an interior. The film's axe scene, in which Bateman lectures Paul Allen on "Hip to Be Square" before killing him, stages the collapse of Mailer's binary on screen. The romance of the psychopath as rebel ends here, in a raincoat on a floor spread with newspapers.

9.6 The American Wife-Killing Novel

The titles themselves trace a national genre. Theodore Dreiser's *An American Tragedy* (1925), drawn from the 1906 case in which Chester Gillette drowned his pregnant girlfriend, Grace Brown, in an Adirondack lake (he was executed in 1908), follows Clyde Griffiths, who allows his pregnant working-class lover to drown so that he may marry into wealth: femicide as the means of class ascent. Mailer's *An American Dream* (1965) makes the murdered wife the route to existential rebirth. Ellis's *American Psycho* (1991) presents femicide not as the means of class ascent but as the consumption that follows its completion. Gillian Flynn's *Gone Girl* (2012) answers the genre from inside: Amy Dunne stages her own murder, weaponizing the cultural script of the murdered wife against the husband the script was written to serve, and her "Cool Girl" monologue dissects the performance of femininity demanded by male desire.

In this genre, American masculinity is consolidated through violence against women in the pursuit, possession or exhaustion of class. Flynn's intervention

reveals the script; Ellis's exposes what remains when the script no longer needs a motive.

9.7 Verdict

The chapter's verdict is methodological. The text's illocution must be read through its form, its perlocution through its history, and its ethics through Beauvoir's question about reciprocity. Neither the fire nor the pedestal; Beauvoir's lucidity together with Millett's suspicion.

10

The Gaze Returned

Harron and Turner's Counter-Adaptation

Harron and Turner's film is a counter-adaptation*: it preserves the novel's events while reversing its gaze, converting horror into laughter at the male subject, and installing a female witness in a narrative built to have none; where the novel delivers anaesthesia, the film delivers testimony.*

10.1 Two Shots at the Surface: From Solanas to Bateman

Mary Harron came to cinema from the New York punk scene of the mid-1970s, which she chronicled as a writer for *Punk* magazine, and from documentary work in Britain. Her first feature, *I Shot Andy Warhol* (1996), co-written with Daniel Minahan, concerned Valerie Solanas, author of the *SCUM Manifesto* (1967), who on 3 June 1968 shot Warhol at his studio, the Factory, critically wounding him, and also wounded the art critic Mario Amaya. The pairing of that film with *American Psycho* is the key to Harron's project.

Warhol was the century's apostle of surface. In a 1967 interview he advised that anyone who wanted to know about him should look at the surface of his paintings, his films and himself—*there's nothing behind it*. *The Philosophy of Andy Warhol* (1975) declared buying more American than thinking. His seriality—soup cans, Marilyns—and his *Death and Disaster* series, in which car crashes and electric chairs became silkscreened commodities, anticipated each element of the Bateman sensibility: surface, repetition, celebrity and the commodified image of death. Solanas's manifesto, for its part, portrayed the male as egocentric, emotionally isolated, incapable of empathy, consumed by money and status, and filling his emptiness with distraction; her proposed remedy was his elimination. Bateman reads as SCUM's male literalized.

Harron filmed the woman who shot the man who was all surface, and then filmed the man who is all surface. Her camera is the second shot. Solanas fired a bullet; Harron fires a satire. The film thus converts the most notorious act of radical-feminist violence in American history into a nonviolent aesthetic operation aimed at the same target.

Guinevere Turner, Harron's co-writer (and the actor who plays Elizabeth), had co-written and starred in Rose Troche's *Go Fish* (1994), a landmark of New Queer Cinema, and has written of a childhood spent in a commune organized around a charismatic male leader. The partnership would continue in *The Notorious Bettie Page* (2005) and *Charlie Says* (2018), the latter concerning the women of the Manson family. Two women whose work repeatedly examines how women are framed by male narratives, and how male charisma organizes violence, wrote the screenplay of the most notorious male text of their generation.

10.2 The Gaze Returned: Mulvey, Neale, Bordo

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema divides labor along gendered lines: woman as image, man as bearer of the look, the female body coded for *to-be-looked-at-ness*, with voyeurism and fetishism as the spectator's defenses. Steve Neale's "Masculinity as Spectacle" (1983) observed that when cinema does display the male body, it disavows the erotic look by routing it through violence and action: the hero is looked at only while he fights.

Harron refuses the disavowal. Bateman's body is displayed in the shower, during his exercises, before the mirror, and the display is rendered absurd rather than heroic. In the film's first threesome, Bateman films the encounter and flexes for the mirror, admiring his own reflection while the women recede to the periphery of the frame. The male gaze is turned back on its bearer and reveals that what it desires is its own image. Susan Bordo's analysis of the newly objectified male body and Faludi's ornamental man find their cinematic demonstration here. The look the camera directs at Bateman is a female look—not by any essence, but by authorship and design. The gaze has been returned.

10.3 Laughter and the Anesthesia of the Heart

Henri Bergson's *Le Rire* (1900) defined the comic as "something mechanical encrusted upon the living": the person who behaves like a thing, the rigidity of automatism where life demands suppleness. Comedy, Bergson added, requires "a momentary anesthesia of the heart"; laughter addresses pure intelligence and needs indifference to function. Bateman is Bergson's comic figure in its purest state: a living being encrusted with ritual, speaking in automatisms.

Harron's conversion of the novel's horror into comedy has two effects. First, it *desublimates* the killer. The serial-killer culture of the 1990s was organized around the sublime aura of figures like Hannibal Lecter; ridicule deprives Bateman of that aura, and mockery becomes a feminist weapon against the grandeur the culture had conferred on male monsters. Second, it *implicates* the audience. To laugh at Bateman is to undergo, temporarily, the anesthesia of the heart that constitutes him permanently. The film's comedy is a controlled dose of the anaesthetic it diagnoses—an immunization, in Esposito's terms—and its moments of horror withdraw the anaesthetic abruptly: the chainsaw falling down the stairwell, the bodies in Paul Allen's closet, Jean's face at the end.

Sara Ahmed's figure of the *feminist killjoy* (*The Promise of Happiness*, 2010; *Living a Feminist Life*, 2017) is the one who refuses to laugh at the joke that wounds. The film negotiates the killjoy's objection through the ethics of the target. Its laughter is aimed at male vanity, rivalry and ritual—at business cards and reservations—and never at the suffering of the women. Where the butt of the joke is power, the killjoy and the satirist converge. The film thereby answers the 1991 controversy with a formal decision: it keeps the violence, removes its pleasure, and gives the pleasure instead to laughter at the man.

10.4 Excision and Emphasis

The adaptation's choices are systematic. Most of the novel's sexualized torture, its cannibalism and its most notorious sequences—Bateman's nail-gun torture of his former girlfriend Bethany before he kills her, his use of a live rat to torture a woman, his murder of a small boy at the zoo—are excised, or reduced to aftermath and implication. Male rivalry—the cards, the restaurant that cannot be booked, the account that belongs to someone else—is moved to the center, and Harron has described the film as fundamentally about male competition. The title sequence announces the method: red drops against white resolve into a sauce on a plate, and blades slicing meat resolve into a restaurant kitchen. The film begins by teaching its audience that, in this world, plating and wounding are one gesture.

The horror canon appears as a consumer good. During his morning exercises Bateman watches Tobe Hooper's *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* (1974), and the film later quotes it in the chainsaw sequence. Horror is not the film's genre so much as an item in its protagonist's collection.

10.5 Jean: The Final Girl as Witness

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identified the *Final Girl* of the slasher film: the watchful, often boyish young woman who sees what is happening, survives, and becomes the locus of the audience's cross-gender identification. Jean, Bateman's secretary, played by Chloë Sevigny, is the film's Final Girl, with a decisive difference: she does not fight. She survives because Bateman, holding a nail gun to the back of her head in his apartment, inexplicably tells her to leave. In Theweleit's terms she is the "white" woman, the one who is spared.

Her real function arrives at the end. Alone in Bateman's office, Jean opens his appointment book and finds page after page of drawings of mutilation. Her face registers horror and grief. She is the first and only character in the diptych who reads Bateman's record *as a record*. The novel has no such witness; its world is constructed so that no one sees. Harron installs a female witness into a narrative structurally designed to exclude one, and Jean's look supplies the recognition the novel's world withholds—not Hegelian recognition between equals, but the recognition of Kierkegaard's editor discovering the seducer's diary, and of Clover's Final Girl, who sees what happened. The film then returns to Harry's and to Bateman's voiceover, and nothing in the world changes. What changes is the spectator's position: for once, there is someone to see with.

The device invites an objection. Does the film locate feeling in a woman so that the man need not feel, reproducing the gendered division of emotional labor that Hochschild described? Chapter 12 answers that Jean's position is structural rather than essential: it is the position of the one who is affected, and it is open to any reader willing to occupy it.

10.6 The Oeuvre and the Moment

Harron's filmography constitutes a sustained inquiry into the framing of women by male narratives and into the surfaces of male celebrity: *I Shot Andy Warhol* (1996); *American Psycho* (2000); *The Notorious Bettie Page* (2005), concerning a pin-up model caught in the moral panics of the 1950s; *The Moth Diaries* (2011); *Alias Grace* (2017), on gendered credibility; *Charlie Says* (2018); and *Dalíland* (2022), on the artist as brand. Within this body of work, *American Psycho* is the film in which the male surface is examined most directly.

The film also belongs to a precise moment. David Fincher's *Fight Club* (1999), from Chuck Palahniuk's 1996 novel, appeared six months earlier, and Faludi's *Stiffed* the same autumn. Both films answer Faludi's question about the ornamental man. *Fight Club*, however ironized, treats male violence as a cure for ornamental emasculation, and its camera adores Tyler Durden's body. Harron treats male violence as the ornament's final accessory, and her camera mocks Bateman's.

10.7 Counter-Adaptation

The chapter's term can now be defined. A *counter-adaptation* preserves its source's events while reversing its gaze, redistributes its affects—horror turned to laughter at the powerful, pleasure removed from violence—and introduces a position the source excludes. Ellis's novel delivers anaesthesia carried to the point of nausea. Harron and Turner's film delivers laughter carried to the point of witness. Together they form the diptych on which the dissertation's synthesis rests.

Part Four

IV

Comparative Horizons and Synthesis

11 Which Humanism Survives Bateman? Feminist and Humanist Counter-Texts

12 Homo Anaestheticus: A Theory of Anaesthetic Sovereignty and the Feminist Remainder

11

Which Humanism Survives Bateman?

Feminist and Humanist Counter-Texts

Bateman is the reductio ad absurdum *of every humanism that grounds dignity in autonomy, self-fashioning or self-creation, since each can be converted without remainder into the entrepreneur of the self; the humanism that survives him is the one feminist and decolonial thought has built from vulnerability, care, reciprocity and narratable uniqueness.*

11.1 The Chameleon Becomes Merchandise

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486) is the founding charter of Renaissance dignity. God, having fixed the natures of all other creatures, left Adam without a determinate seat, form or function, so that man might fashion himself in whatever shape he chose, sinking to the brutes or rising to the divine. The human is a chameleon, and his dignity is his indeterminacy. Stephen Greenblatt's *Renaissance Self-Fashioning* (1980) qualified the charter historically: sixteenth-century self-fashioning proceeded through submission to an absolute authority and through attack upon something perceived as alien, strange or hostile.

Both of Greenblatt's conditions recur in Bateman. He submits to an absolute authority—the market and its idols, from the reservation list to the developer whose book he reveres—and he fashions himself against an alien other: the homeless, women, racial and sexual minorities. Pico's chameleon, offered every form, chooses neither beast nor angel but merchandise. Leonardo's Vitruvian Man (c. 1490), proportioned within circle and square as the measure of all things, became the emblem of a humanism whose universal was, as Rosi Braidotti's *The*

Posthuman (2013) argues, white, male, European and able-bodied, defined against sexualized, racialized and naturalized others. Bateman before his mirror after his exercises is Vitruvian Man in a gym: the measure of all things, measuring himself.

11.2 Ornament and Reason: Wollstonecraft's Inheritance

Enlightenment humanism grounded dignity in rational autonomy, and Chapters 2 and 6 showed that formal reason alone cannot hold that ground against price. Mary Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) extended the claim of reason to women and directed its fiercest criticism at an education that formed women as ornaments—pleasing, absorbed in appearance, governed by manners and sensibility rather than reason—with Rousseau's Sophie in *Émile* (1762) as its principal target. Wollstonecraft also observed that soldiers, like the women of her class, were shaped by display and manners rather than by reason, a comparison that anticipates Theweleit's soldier males by nearly two centuries.

The ornamental condition has since been generalized. Faludi's ornamental culture and Bordo's objectified male body describe its extension to men, and Bateman shows what it produces in a man who also holds power: not a victim of ornament but a predator in ornament. Wollstonecraft's diagnosis was correct; its gendering was historical rather than essential. Ralph Waldo Emerson's "Self-Reliance" (1841) supplied the American variant of the self-originating subject, and James Truslow Adams's *The Epic of America* (1931) named its horizon "the American Dream." Bateman is self-reliance terminally commodified. Nonconformity has become the most conformist of styles, trust in oneself has become trust in a brand, and the American Dream has acquired the double sense the fantasist reading exploits: a dream of success, and a dream in which the murders may or may not occur.

11.3 The Paper-Knife and the Serious Man: Existentialist Humanism

In *L'existentialisme est un humanisme* (1946), Sartre contrasted the paper-knife, manufactured according to a prior concept so that its essence precedes its existence, with the human being, whose existence precedes essence: man is nothing other than what he makes of himself. Bateman reverses the formula. He is a manufactured object whose concept—an idea of a Patrick Bateman—precedes his existence, a paper-knife in a suit, and his self-making is the assembly of a specification.

Beauvoir's *Pour une morale de l'ambiguïté* (1947) gave existentialist humanism its ethical typology. The *sub-man* flees his freedom into apathy and dullness. The *serious man* subordinates freedom to an idol—wealth, status, a cause—and will sacrifice others to it. The *nihilist* wills nothingness; the *adventurer* uses others as

instruments of his exploits. Bateman unites all four: the sub-man's apathy, the serious man's idolatry of the card and the reservation, the nihilist's destructiveness, the adventurer's instrumentalization. Beauvoir's counter-principle, that to will oneself free is also to will others free, names the reciprocity he lacks. *Le Deuxième Sexe* (1949) analyzed the masculine monopoly of transcendence; Cameron and Frazer later read sexual murder as its counterfeit. In Bateman's world, transcendence itself has been commodified, and a transcendence that can be purchased transcends nothing. Fromm's radical humanism (Chapter 4) survives as diagnosis, but it presupposes a productive human essence that the novel gives us no reason to trust.

11.4 The Will to Change: hooks and the Wound of Patriarchal Masculinity

bell hooks's *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center* (1984) defined feminism as the movement to end sexist oppression and insisted that men could be comrades in it rather than its enemies. *The Will to Change* (2004) located patriarchy's first act of violence not against women but against boys, from whom it demands a *psychic self-mutilation*—the killing of their emotional selves—as the price of masculinity; emotional numbness becomes the norm, and love the casualty. Read through hooks, Bateman's anaesthesia is neither innate psychopathy nor mere postmodern style but the completed form of the mutilation patriarchy requires. His closing confession of a constant pain is the scar. hooks's humanism insists that men can change; the novel is the portrait of the unchanged, and the film's final image of a woman weeping over his record supplies the grief patriarchy forbade him.

Raewyn Connell's *Masculinities* (1995) theorized *hegemonic masculinity*, the culturally exalted form that legitimates men's dominance and subordinates other masculinities. Connell and Julian Wood's study of "transnational business masculinity" (2005)—egocentric, marked by conditional loyalties, a declining sense of responsibility for others and the commodification of sexual relations—reads as a sociological portrait of Bateman published fourteen years after the novel. Michael Kimmel's *Manhood in America* (1996) described masculinity as a homosocial performance staged for other men's approval; the business card scene is its miniature. A caution is required. Sally Robinson's *Marked Men* (2000) and David Savran's *Taking It Like a Man* (1998) showed that narratives of wounded white masculinity can serve to recenter it. A reading of Bateman as patriarchy's victim risks exactly this. hooks avoids the risk by naming the wound while refusing the alibi: the mutilated man remains accountable for the mutilations he inflicts.

11.5 Care, Vulnerability, Grievability

Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) articulated an ethics of care and responsibility, relational rather than rule-based, against the justice-centered model of moral development. Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) described the carer's *engrossment* in the cared-for and the *motivational displacement* through which another's needs become one's own; Bateman is incapable of either, since his attention never leaves himself except to take inventory. Joan Tronto's *Moral Boundaries* (1993) made care political, distinguishing four phases—caring about, taking care of, care-giving and care-receiving—and naming *privileged irresponsibility*: the capacity of the powerful to ignore care needs because others meet them out of sight. Bateman is privileged irresponsibility incarnate, sustained by the service infrastructure described in Chapter 7. Virginia Held's *The Ethics of Care* (2006) consolidated the tradition.

Martha Albertson Fineman's "The Vulnerable Subject" (2008) proposed vulnerability as the universal and constant condition of embodied life, against the liberal fiction of the autonomous, self-sufficient individual. Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) offered shared precariousness as the basis of an ethics of nonviolence, and *The Force of Nonviolence* (2020) argued for the radical equality of grievability. Nussbaum's *Women and Human Development* (2000) listed emotions and affiliation among the central human capabilities—precisely those Bateman lacks. Adriana Cavarero's *Orrorismo* (2007; trans. *Horrorism*, 2009) distinguished horror from terror: horror names violence against the defenseless, an offense against the singularity of the body whose dismemberment is an ontological crime against the uniqueness of the human figure. Her *Inclinazioni* (2013; trans. *Inclinations*, 2016) criticized philosophy's upright, self-sufficient subject and opposed to it the inclined posture of care. Bateman's verticality—the tower, the armored upright body, the view from the office—stands against Jean's inclination over the appointment book.

11.6 The Decolonial Correction

Aimé Césaire (Chapter 6) and Frantz Fanon's *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961) indicted a Europe that never ceased to speak of Man while massacring men wherever it found them; Fanon's conclusion was to leave that Europe behind and to work out new concepts for a new humanity. Sylvia Wynter called for a move beyond the overrepresentation of Man toward a new genre of the human. The correction for any humanism after Bateman is therefore methodological. It cannot be built by extending Man's dignity downward to those he excluded; it must be reconstructed from the standpoint of the dysselected—the homeless man, the renamed sex worker, the dry cleaners—whose vantage reveals what the humanist universal concealed.

11.7 Posthumanism and Its Limits

Donna Haraway's "A Manifesto for Cyborgs" (1985) embraced the cyborg as a feminist figure of hybridity, confounding the boundaries between human and animal, organism and machine, on which domination relied. Bateman is the cyborg's dystopian twin: a body maintained like a machine and fused with devices and products, yet without any confusion of boundaries—an armored monad whose integration with commodities produces closure rather than hybridity. N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999) warned against an informational posthumanism that erases embodiment; Braidotti's affirmative posthumanism seeks a relational, embodied subject. The novel's lesson for posthumanism is sobering. The dissolution of the humanist subject can arrive not as liberation but as fungibility; the end of man can come as a sale. A humanism must be retained, but rebuilt.

11.8 Literary Counter-Texts

Patricia Highsmith's *The Talented Mr. Ripley* (1955) follows a murderer who assumes his victim's identity to secure access to a class; Bateman needs no identity theft, because identities are already generic, and he is taken for Marcus Halberstam without trying. Jim Thompson's *The Killer Inside Me* (1952), whose deputy torments his interlocutors with clichés, is the American precursor of banal speech as a mask. Nabokov's *Lolita* (1955) enlists readers in Humbert Humbert's aestheticization of his abduction and repeated rape of Dolores Haze, a twelve-year-old girl, and much of its moral work lies in teaching them to resist that seduction; Ellis's anti-lyricism refuses to offer the seduction at all, withholding the beauty that would make complicity pleasant. In Fitzgerald's *The Great Gatsby* (1925), whose working title alluded to Petronius's Trimalchio, Daisy weeps over Gatsby's shirts, the commodity as the occasion of tears; Bateman, surrounded by shirts, weeps over nothing. Don DeLillo's *White Noise* (1985), with its litanies of brand names, and *Cosmopolis* (2003; filmed by David Cronenberg, 2012), whose billionaire asset manager crosses Manhattan in a limousine as his fortune and self disintegrate, give Bateman a millennial heir.

Ottessa Moshfegh's *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* (2018), frequently compared to Ellis's novel, follows an affluent young woman in Manhattan in 2000–2001 who attempts to sleep for a year on pharmaceuticals. It is anaesthesia turned inward. Bateman exports his numbness as violence against others; Moshfegh's narrator imports hers as chemical hibernation. The two novels describe gendered responses to a single anaesthetic condition, the male externalizing and the female withdrawing, and Moshfegh's ends with the attacks of September 11, the real breaking into a sensorium that had sealed itself. Atwood's *Alias Grace* (Chapter 8) and Flynn's *Gone Girl* (Chapter 9) complete the feminist counter-canon.

11.9 Verdict

The humanisms of autonomy (Kant), self-fashioning (Pico), self-reliance (Emerson) and self-creation (Sartre) fail before Bateman not because they are false but because each can be converted, without remainder, into the entrepreneur of the self. What survives is the humanism that feminist and decolonial thought has constructed from the other end: Wollstonecraft's critique of ornament, Beauvoir's reciprocity, hooks's will to change, Tronto's care, Fineman's vulnerability, Butler's grievability and Cavarero's *who*, corrected by Césaire, Fanon and Wynter. Chapter 12 assembles it.

12

Homo Anaestheticus

A Theory of Anaesthetic Sovereignty and the Feminist Remainder

*The preceding chapters converge on a single figure—*homo anaestheticus*, the human being whose capacity to be affected has been suspended by the conversion of all value into price—and on a single political form,* anaesthetic sovereignty*, whose failures leave a remainder from which a feminist humanism of the* who *can be built.*

12.1 Aisthēsis and Its Negation

Aristotle's *De Anima* (II.12) defined perception, *aisthēsis*, as the capacity to receive sensible forms without their matter, as wax receives the impress of a signet ring without its iron or gold. To perceive is to be affected. Alexander Gottlieb Baumgarten's *Aesthetica* (1750) founded aesthetics as the science of sensory cognition, the knowledge that comes through being affected. The modern medical term *anaesthesia* was proposed by Oliver Wendell Holmes in November 1846, weeks after the public demonstration of ether at the Massachusetts General Hospital and two years after Marx drafted his Paris manuscripts on alienation. The coincidence is emblematic: the technical abolition of sensation and the theoretical diagnosis of estrangement belong to the same decade.

Susan Buck-Morss's "Aesthetics and Anaesthetics" (1992) joined these histories. Modernity, she argued, overwhelms the sensorium with shock; the sensorium defends itself by numbing; the phantasmagoria of commodities supplies a compensatory anaesthetic; and fascism exploited the resulting condition by aestheticizing politics. *Homo anaestheticus* is the subject in whom this defensive numbing has ceased to be a defense and become a constitution—not a response to

shock but the precondition of a self assembled from commodities. He cannot receive the form of another because he has no wax, only surface.

12.2 The Four Anaesthesias

The dissertation has identified anaesthesia in four registers, each with its originators, its textual site and the remainder it fails to absorb.

Register	What fails	Principal originators	Textual site	Remainder
Affective	The capacity to feel	Sade, Blanchot, Simmel, Ballard, Jameson	The flat narration; murder and menu at equal specific gravity	The reader's nausea
Ethical	The perception of the other	Kant, Levinas, Nussbaum, Honneth	The misrecognitions; violence against faces	The face; the unnarrated *who*
Socio-juridical	The registration of acts	Becker, Fricker, Esposito, Agamben, Butler	Undecidability; the cleaned apartment; the answering machine	The witness, Jean
Aesthetic	The reader's responsiveness	Bergson, Ngai, Jameson	Catalogs, repetition, comedy	The rupture of horror

The four registers form a causal chain. Affective anaesthesia in the subject produces ethical anaesthesia toward others, because one who cannot feel cannot perceive what another's face demands. A society composed of such subjects cannot register their acts, so ethical anaesthesia becomes socio-juridical anaesthesia. And the forms adequate to representing such a society numb those who read them, so socio-juridical anaesthesia becomes aesthetic anaesthesia. The anaesthesia is therefore total in principle. That is why its failures—the remainders in the final column—are the decisive objects of analysis.

12.3 Anaesthetic Sovereignty

Three genealogies of sovereignty converge in Bateman. The first is Sadean *apathy*: sovereignty through insensibility, achieved by discipline (Chapter 2). The second is Carl Schmitt's decisionist sovereign, who decides on the exception (Chapter 8): personal, juridical, singular. The third is *consumer sovereignty*, the phrase W. H. Hutt gave to economics in *Economists and the Public* (1936): the doctrine that the preferences of consumers constitute the final authority of the economic order. It is impersonal, distributed and continuous.

Anaesthetic sovereignty may now be defined as consumer sovereignty that has acquired the prerogative of the exception, exercised with an apathy that is not

achieved but issued. Its defining paradox is that it is simultaneously total and null. It is total because no limit resists it: there is no taboo to transgress, no witness to see and no law that will act. It is null because nothing it does is registered. It is a sovereignty indistinguishable from impotence: the sovereign can do anything, and nothing he does counts. Bateman's closing recognition that his confession has meant nothing is the sovereign's self-knowledge. Schmitt's formula is inverted. This is not a sovereign who decides on the exception but an exception that has produced a sovereign without anyone deciding.

Carla Freccero (1997) argued that the figure of the serial killer individualizes, and so disavows, a violence that is collective and historical. The concept of anaesthetic sovereignty restores the collective dimension. Bateman is not an exception to his society's rule but that rule personified, and the Bateman quadrilateral of Chapter 7—social reproduction, expropriated populations, nature and the polity—is the map of his territory.

12.4 Somatic Satire

Frye's requirement that satire possess a norm (Introduction) can now be answered. *American Psycho* contains no norm in its characters or in its narrator's discourse, but the norm has not vanished. It has been relocated into the body of the reader. The novel's violence is engineered to nauseate rather than to arouse or thrill, and the reader's revulsion is the last site at which the culture's lost norm survives: the body refusing what the world of the book accepts. Kristeva's abject names this boundary response. Sianne Ngai's *Ugly Feelings* (2005) supplies the term for the novel's accumulative effect: *stuplimity*, the conjunction of stupefaction and sublimity produced by massive repetition, an aesthetic of exhaustion she identified in Stein and Beckett. The catalogs induce a stuplime fatigue, and the horror sequences rupture it.

Disgust, however, is a treacherous moral instrument. Aurel Kolnai's phenomenology of disgust ("Der Ekel," 1929) analyzed its intentional structure; William Ian Miller's *The Anatomy of Disgust* (1997) showed its role in marking hierarchy; and Martha Nussbaum's *Hiding from Humanity* (2004) warned that disgust is projective, attaching to the vulnerable and the subordinated as figures of contamination. Bateman's own violence is fueled by exactly this projective disgust—at the poor, at women, at gay men. The novel's formal ethics, then, is not the production of disgust as such but its *re-aiming*. It redirects the reader's disgust from Bateman's targets to Bateman's acts, from the abject to the powerful.

The dissertation accordingly defines *somatic satire* as a satire whose norm survives only as an involuntary bodily response, and whose ethical work consists in

re-aiming that response from the vulnerable toward the powerful. Harron's comedy performs the parallel operation in the register of laughter: it administers Bergson's anesthesia of the heart and then withdraws it.

12.5 Judgment, Suspension, Aesthesis

Marco Abel (2001; 2007) argued that judgment is not an exit: moral judgment applied to the novel's violence forecloses an encounter with its affective intensities. Namwali Serpell (2010) analyzed the ethics of a reading suspended by repetition. Both arguments correctly diagnose the failure of moralism. Judgment applied from outside—the boycott, the indictment of the author—forecloses the text before it can act.

But suspension elevated into method reproduces the object's anaesthesia as a critical posture. A criticism that refuses to be affected is homologous with Bateman. The alternative proposed here is *aesthesis*: the restored capacity to be affected, which precedes judgment and grounds it, as Honneth's recognition precedes cognition and Levinas's face precedes ontology. Judgment is not an exit; neither is suspension. Aesthesis is the door the sign denies.

12.6 The Feminist Remainder

Anaesthetic sovereignty fails to complete itself at four points, and these failures constitute what this dissertation calls the *feminist remainder*.

The first is the *material remainder*, the indigestible referent. In "Tries to Cook and Eat Girl," consumption is attempted and not completed. Adams's absent referent does not wholly vanish, and the body resists total assimilation.

The second is the *testimonial remainder*, the witness. Jean reads the record as a record. Harron and Turner's addition makes visible the position that the novel's world is constructed to exclude.

The third is the *somatic remainder*, the reader's body: nausea, the rupture of stuplimity, the involuntary refusal.

The fourth is the *narrative remainder*, the unnamed name. The woman renamed "Christie" never receives her own name. Its absence is legible, and the absence accuses.

The remainder is called feminist not because these positions are feminine by essence—the objection raised in Chapter 10 against locating feeling in Jean—but because feminist philosophy theorized each of them while the humanist tradition grounded dignity elsewhere. Material vulnerability was theorized by Adams, Federici and Fineman; witness and credibility by Clover and Fricker; the body by Kristeva, Bordo and Butler; the narratable *who* by Cavarero, reading Arendt. Jean's

position is structural, not sexual. It is the position of the one who is affected, and it is open to any reader. The feminist remainder is what anaesthetic sovereignty cannot absorb, and it is where a new humanism begins.

12.7 The Humanism of the Who

The constructive proposal can be stated as six propositions, each grounded in the remainders and each answering a feature of anaesthetic sovereignty.

1. *Uniqueness, not autonomy, grounds dignity.* Each person is an unrepeatable *who* whose story can be told only by another (Arendt, Cavarero). Fungibility is the denial of uniqueness, and price is fungibility made general.
2. *Vulnerability, not self-sufficiency, is the universal human condition* (Fineman, Butler). The anaesthetic subject's immunity is a fantasy of invulnerability purchased with the violability of others.
3. *Grievability is the measure of membership* (Butler). A life counts as human insofar as its loss can be registered, and the novel's undecidability is the formal index of ungrievability.
4. *Care is the infrastructure of personhood* (Tronto, Glenn, Fraser). Privileged irresponsibility is the social form of anaesthesia.
5. *Recognition precedes cognition* (Honneth, Levinas). Reification is a forgetting, and narration—the telling of the *who*—is its remedy.
6. *The human is built from below* (Césaire, Fanon, Wynter), from the standpoint of the dysselected, not extended downward from Man.

The propositions answer Bateman point for point: against price, uniqueness; against immunity, vulnerability; against undecidability, grievability; against privileged irresponsibility, care; against forgetting, narration; against Man2, the dysselected. This is the *humanism of the who*: a humanism whose foundation is not a property the human possesses but an exposure the human undergoes.

12.8 Four Reading Positions and Reading as Exhumation

The diptych offers its readers four positions, each prefigured within the texts or their reception.

Position	Figure	Relation to the record	What it reproduces
Disbelief	Harold Carnes	Hears the confession as a joke, or the murders as "only a dream"	Credibility immunity

Position	Figure	Relation to the record	What it reproduces
Refusal	The 1991 boycott	Declines to read, burning the record together with the crime	The victims' unrecorded erasure
Identificati on	The memetic imitator	Adopts the routine, discards the horror	Perlocutionary capture; the itemized subject
Witness	Jean	Reads the record as a record and is affected	The feminist remainder

The first three positions reproduce, in reading, the structures the text diagnoses: impunity, erasure and itemization. Only the fourth breaks the circuit. The dissertation names the practice proper to it *reading as exhumation*: the ethical labor of restoring the ledger's dead to the status of persons. Exhumation in this sense is not forensic. It does not require deciding the undecidable. It requires only that the reader attend to the victims the narration renders as items, ask after the *who* where the text supplies only the *what*, and refuse the verdict that it does not matter whether they died. In fiction, the dead are exactly as real as the text makes them, and the reader's grief is the only funeral they receive.

12.9 The Thesis Restated

American Psycho, read as a diptych, is a theory of *homo anaestheticus*. Ellis's novel carries anaesthesia to the point of nausea, so that the culture's lost norm reappears in the reader's body. Harron and Turner's film carries laughter to the point of witness, so that the recognition the novel's world withholds reappears in a woman's face. Between them, the two texts demonstrate that a world of pure price produces a sovereign who can do anything and a violence that counts for nothing, and they locate in the remainders of that violence—the indigestible body, the witness, the revolted reader, the missing name—the ground of a humanism that begins not with what we are but with who we are to one another.

Coda

After the Exit

The Idea of a Patrick Bateman in Circulation

The novel's self-description has been fulfilled in a medium it could not foresee: "an idea of a Patrick Bateman" now circulates independently of the novel, the film and their satire, which is the strongest available confirmation that the text describes a subject made of transmissible surfaces.

The Author Haunted

Ellis's *Lunar Park* (2005) is a mock-memoir in which a fictional Bret Easton Ellis, living in suburban domesticity, is haunted by his dead father, by a house that seems to rearrange itself and by a killer who reenacts the murders of *American Psycho*. Ellis has linked Bateman in interviews to his own alienation in late-1980s Manhattan and to his conflicted relationship with his father, a real-estate developer. In *Lunar Park*, the creator cannot exit his creation. The sign over the door at Harry's turns out to apply to the author as well.

The Commodity's Revenge

The franchise followed the logic the novel described. *American Psycho 2* (2002), a direct-to-video sequel with no relation to Ellis's text, concerns a young woman who killed Bateman as a child and becomes a killer herself: the feminist inversion, sold back as franchise merchandise. The stage musical by Duncan Sheik and Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa (London, 2013; Broadway, 2016), scored in the synthesizer idiom of the decade it satirizes, converted the satire of commodities into a commodity. Adorno's thesis that the culture industry absorbs its own critique is confirmed here at the level of reception history.

The Memetic Afterlife

From around 2020, short-form video and image culture recast Bateman as an aspirational figure. The morning routine circulates as a self-improvement template. The business card scene and the line about returning videotapes circulate as reaction images. Bateman has been installed in the iconography of the "sigma male" and in a "literally me" canon of alienated male protagonists that also includes Travis Bickle, Arthur Fleck and Tyler Durden. The phenomenon is easily dismissed as ironic play or misreading. The argument of this dissertation suggests that it should instead be read as the text's own thesis realized at scale, in four respects.

First, it realizes Baudrillard's precession of simulacra. An abstraction without a person now circulates on its own, detached not only from Bateman but from the satire that framed him. The idea has outlived the novel's irony.

Second, it realizes the perlocutionary capture analyzed in Chapter 9. A text whose illocution was satirical has acquired an uptake that keeps the routine and discards the horror.

Third, it reverses the satire's direction. The novel parodied the consumer manual exemplified by *The Yuppie Handbook*; the meme converts the parody back into a manual, now addressed to a generation trained in wellness content and productivity culture. The itemized subject resurfaces as a lifestyle.

Fourth, and most precisely, the meme removes the two elements Harron and Turner added. It strips out the comic target, which was the man, and the witness, who was Jean. In this sense it is a counter-counter-adaptation: it restores the novel's anaesthesia while discarding the novel's nausea, which is to say it preserves what the diptych diagnosed and removes everything that resisted it.

The Ego Ideal

The novel installed Donald Trump—in 1991 a developer, celebrity and author of *The Art of the Deal*—as Bateman's ego ideal. Trump subsequently won the presidency in 2016 and again in 2024, a convergence Ellis has remarked on in interviews and one that has generated substantial commentary. This study's concern is formal rather than partisan. In 1991 the novel identified the fusion of celebrity, real estate and personal brand as an emerging form of authority—the brand-person—and the fourth corner of the Bateman quadrilateral, public power experienced through television, anticipated the mediatization of politics more broadly.

A Further Adaptation

A new film adaptation was announced in 2024 under the direction of Luca Guadagnino. Whether it will add a third panel to the diptych—and whether that panel will preserve the comic target and the witness or remove them—lies beyond the scope of this study.

No Exit

THIS IS NOT AN EXIT turns out to be literally true of the text's reception. The idea has escaped the book, and there is no exit from its circulation. What remains is the response this dissertation has called exhumation: reading past the idea to the people the ledger erased.

Conclusion

This dissertation has argued that American Psycho*, read as a diptych of Ellis's novel and Harron and Turner's film, constitutes a theory of* homo anaestheticus*: the subject produced when dignity collapses into price, who can neither be affected nor register as an agent, and whose violence is therefore at once total and null. Its contribution can be summarized in five claims.*

Contributions

The first is a unified theory. The concepts of *homo anaestheticus* and *anaesthetic sovereignty* integrate affective, ethical, juridical and aesthetic analyses that criticism of the novel has generally conducted in isolation: the satirical paradigm's attention to consumer culture, the obscenity-critical paradigm's attention to gendered violence, the psychiatric paradigm's attention to affectlessness, and the affective turn's attention to the reader's experience. Each is shown to describe one register of a single condition.

The second is a reinterpretation of the novel's central crux. The undecidability of the murders is read not as a puzzle but as the formal transcription of impunity, and the concept of *credibility immunity* is introduced as a category of epistemic injustice: the structural twin of testimonial injustice, in which the identity prejudice that silences victims also shields the privileged confessant.

The third is the *cannibal ledger* and its map, the *Bateman quadrilateral*, which align the novel's victimology with Nancy Fraser's account of capital's background conditions. Together with the concept of the *failed empirical metaphysics*, they reframe the violence as the economy's consumption of its own foundations and as a search for dignity conducted with instruments that can only find matter.

The fourth is the diptych reading and the concept of *counter-adaptation*. The novel carries anaesthesia to the point of nausea; the film carries laughter to the point of witness. Neither text alone makes the argument the two make together, and Harron and Turner's film emerges not as a softened version of the novel but as its feminist completion.

The fifth is constructive. The *feminist humanism of the who*, grounded in uniqueness, vulnerability, grievability, care, recognition and the standpoint of the dysselected, and the practice of *reading as exhumation* offer a third position between the boycott and the defense that divided feminism in 1991. It neither burns the text nor laughs with it, but reads it as a record of persons.

Limitations

The corpus is confined to the novel and the film; the sequel, the musical and the memetic afterlife are treated only as reception. The memetic afterlife is characterized descriptively rather than measured. Despite the decolonial correction of Chapters 6 and 11, the comparative frame remains predominantly Euro-American. The Beckerian analysis applies an economic model to a fiction and makes no empirical claim about criminal justice. The Bateman quadrilateral is an interpretive alignment, not a claim about authorial intention.

Directions for Further Research

Four lines of inquiry follow. An empirical reception study could test whether the memetic afterlife in fact preserves the routine and discards the horror, as the Coda argues. The concept of credibility immunity could be applied to documented cases of elite impunity and to the history of disbelieved confessions. The anaesthetic subject could be traced comparatively across other national literatures of financialization. And the announced new adaptation will offer a test of whether the diptych becomes a triptych, and of which remainders a third panel chooses to keep.

Coda to the Conclusion

The novel ends at a door that is not an exit. The film ends with a woman reading a book of drawings and weeping. Between those two endings lies the choice the text leaves to every reader: the sign or the witness. This dissertation has argued for the witness.

Works Cited

I. Primary Texts and Adaptations

Ellis, Bret Easton. *American Psycho*. New York: Vintage Contemporaries, 1991.

———. *Glamorama*. New York: Knopf, 1998.

———. *Less Than Zero*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 1985.

———. *Lunar Park*. New York: Knopf, 2005.

———. *The Rules of Attraction*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 1987.

Freeman, Morgan J., dir. *American Psycho 2*. 2002.

Harron, Mary, dir. *American Psycho*. Screenplay by Mary Harron and Guinevere Turner. Lions Gate Films, 2000.

Sheik, Duncan (music and lyrics), and Roberto Aguirre-Sacasa (book). *American Psycho: A New Musical*. London, 2013; Broadway, 2016.

II. Criticism on *American Psycho* and Its Contexts

Abel, Marco. "Judgment Is Not an Exit: Toward an Affective Criticism of Violence with *American Psycho*." *Angelaki* 6, no. 3 (2001): 137–54.

———. *Violent Affect: Literature, Cinema, and Critique after Representation*. Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2007.

American Psychiatric Association. *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*. 3rd ed., rev. (*DSM-III-R*). Washington, DC: American Psychiatric Association, 1987.

Annesley, James. *Blank Fictions: Consumerism, Culture and the Contemporary American Novel*. London: Pluto Press, 1998.

Babiak, Paul, and Robert D. Hare. *Snakes in Suits: When Psychopaths Go to Work*. New York: Regan Books, 2006.

Baelo-Allué, Sonia. *Bret Easton Ellis's Controversial Fiction: Writing Between High and Low Culture*. London: Continuum, 2011.

Cleckley, Hervey. *The Mask of Sanity*. St. Louis: C. V. Mosby, 1941.

Freccero, Carla. "Historical Violence, Censorship, and the Serial Killer: The Case of *American Psycho*." *Diacritics* 27, no. 2 (1997): 44–58.

Hare, Robert D. *The Hare Psychopathy Checklist–Revised*. Toronto: Multi-Health Systems, 1991.

Jenkins, Philip. *Using Murder: The Social Construction of Serial Homicide*. New York: Aldine de Gruyter, 1994.

Mailer, Norman. "Children of the Pied Piper." *Vanity Fair*, March 1991.

Murphet, Julian. *Bret Easton Ellis's American Psycho: A Reader's Guide*. New York: Continuum, 2002.

Rosenblatt, Roger. "Snuff This Book! Will Bret Easton Ellis Get Away with Murder?" *New York Times Book Review*, 16 December 1990.

Seltzer, Mark. *Serial Killers: Death and Life in America's Wound Culture*. New York: Routledge, 1998.

Serpell, C. Namwali. "Repetition and the Ethics of Suspended Reading in *American Psycho*." *Critique: Studies in Contemporary Fiction* 51, no. 1 (2010): 47–73.

Young, Elizabeth. "The Beast in the Jungle, the Figure in the Carpet: Bret Easton Ellis's *American Psycho*." In Elizabeth Young and Graham Caveney, *Shopping in Space: Essays on America's Blank Generation Fiction*. London: Serpent's Tail, 1992.

III. Philosophy, Theory, and Criticism

Adams, Carol J. *The Sexual Politics of Meat: A Feminist-Vegetarian Critical Theory*. New York: Continuum, 1990.

Adams, James Truslow. *The Epic of America*. Boston: Little, Brown, 1931.

Adorno, Theodor W., with George Simpson. "On Popular Music." *Studies in Philosophy and Social Science* 9 (1941): 17–48.

Agamben, Giorgio. *Homo sacer: Il potere sovrano e la nuda vita*. Turin: Einaudi, 1995. Trans. Daniel Heller-Roazen, *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1998.

Ahmed, Sara. *Living a Feminist Life*. Durham: Duke University Press, 2017.

———. *The Promise of Happiness*. Durham: Duke University Press, 2010.

Arendt, Hannah. *Eichmann in Jerusalem: A Report on the Banality of Evil*. New York: Viking, 1963.

———. *The Human Condition*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958.

———. Letter to Gershom Scholem, 24 July 1963. In *The Jewish Writings*, edited by Jerome Kohn and Ron H. Feldman. New York: Schocken, 2007.

———. *The Origins of Totalitarianism*. New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1951.

Aristotle. *De Anima*; *Poetics*; *Politics*.

Austin, J. L. *How to Do Things with Words*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1962.

Baldwin, James. "The Black Boy Looks at the White Boy." *Esquire*, May 1961.

Barthes, Roland. *Sade, Fourier, Loyola*. Paris: Seuil, 1971.

Bataille, Georges. *L'Érotisme*. Paris: Minuit, 1957.

———. *La Part maudite*. Paris: Minuit, 1949.

Baudrillard, Jean. *Simulacres et simulation*. Paris: Galilée, 1981.

———. *La Société de consommation*. Paris: Denoël, 1970.

———. *Le Système des objets*. Paris: Gallimard, 1968.

Baumgarten, Alexander Gottlieb. *Aesthetica*. Frankfurt an der Oder, 1750–58.

Beauvoir, Simone de. *Le Deuxième Sexe*. Paris: Gallimard, 1949.

———. "Faut-il brûler Sade?" *Les Temps modernes* (1951–52). Repr. in *Privilèges*. Paris: Gallimard, 1955.

———. *Pour une morale de l'ambiguïté*. Paris: Gallimard, 1947.

Becker, Gary S. "Crime and Punishment: An Economic Approach." *Journal of Political Economy* 76, no. 2 (1968): 169–217.

———. *Human Capital*. New York: National Bureau of Economic Research / Columbia University Press, 1964.

Bell, Daniel. *The Cultural Contradictions of Capitalism*. New York: Basic Books, 1976.

Benjamin, Walter. "Kapitalismus als Religion" (1921); "Paris, die Hauptstadt des XIX. Jahrhunderts" (1935); "Das Kunstwerk im Zeitalter seiner technischen Reproduzierbarkeit" (1935–36); "Über einige Motive bei Baudelaire" (1939). In *Gesammelte Schriften*, edited by Rolf Tiedemann and Hermann Schweppenhäuser. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1972–89.

Bergson, Henri. *Le Rire: Essai sur la signification du comique*. Paris: Alcan, 1900. Trans. Cloudesley Brereton and Fred Rothwell, *Laughter*. London: Macmillan, 1911.

Blanchot, Maurice. "La raison de Sade." In *Lautréamont et Sade*. Paris: Minuit, 1949.

Booth, Wayne C. *The Rhetoric of Fiction*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1961.

Bordo, Susan. *The Male Body: A New Look at Men in Public and in Private*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1999.

———. *Unbearable Weight: Feminism, Western Culture, and the Body*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993.

Bourdieu, Pierre. *La Distinction: Critique sociale du jugement*. Paris: Minuit, 1979.

Braidotti, Rosi. *The Posthuman*. Cambridge: Polity, 2013.

Buck-Morss, Susan. "Aesthetics and Anaesthetics: Walter Benjamin's Artwork Essay Reconsidered." *October* 62 (1992): 3–41.

Butler, Judith. *The Force of Nonviolence*. London: Verso, 2020.

———. *Frames of War: When Is Life Grievable?* London: Verso, 2009.

———. *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity*. New York: Routledge, 1990.

———. *Precarious Life: The Powers of Mourning and Violence*. London: Verso, 2004.

Cameron, Deborah, and Elizabeth Frazer. *The Lust to Kill: A Feminist Investigation of Sexual Murder*. Cambridge: Polity, 1987.

Camus, Albert. *L'Homme révolté*. Paris: Gallimard, 1951.

Caputi, Jane. *The Age of Sex Crime*. Bowling Green, OH: Bowling Green State University Popular Press, 1987.

Cavarero, Adriana. *Inclinazioni: Critica della rettitudine*. Milan: Raffaello Cortina, 2013. Trans. Amanda Minervini and Adam Sitze, *Inclinations*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2016.

———. *Orrorismo, ovvero della violenza sull'inerme*. Milan: Feltrinelli, 2007. Trans. William McCuaig, *Horrorism: Naming Contemporary Violence*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2009.

———. *Tu che mi guardi, tu che mi racconti*. Milan: Feltrinelli, 1997. Trans. Paul A. Kottman, *Relating Narratives: Storytelling and Selfhood*. London: Routledge, 2000.

Césaire, Aimé. *Discours sur le colonialisme*. Paris: Réclame, 1950. Trans. Joan Pinkham. New York: Monthly Review Press, 1972.

Clover, Carol J. *Men, Women, and Chain Saws: Gender in the Modern Horror Film*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1992.

Connell, R. W. *Masculinities*. Cambridge: Polity, 1995.

Connell, R. W., and Julian Wood. "Globalization and Business Masculinities." *Men and Masculinities* 7, no. 4 (2005): 347–64.

Creed, Barbara. *The Monstrous-Feminine: Film, Feminism, Psychoanalysis*. London: Routledge, 1993.

Debord, Guy. *La Société du spectacle*. Paris: Buchet-Chastel, 1967.

Deleuze, Gilles. *Présentation de Sacher-Masoch*. Paris: Minuit, 1967.

De Quincey, Thomas. "On Murder Considered as One of the Fine Arts." *Blackwood's Edinburgh Magazine*, February 1827.

Dworkin, Andrea. *Pornography: Men Possessing Women*. New York: Putnam, 1981.

Eco, Umberto. *La vertigine della lista*. Milan: Bompiani, 2009.

Ehrenreich, Barbara. *Fear of Falling: The Inner Life of the Middle Class*. New York: Pantheon, 1989.

———. Foreword to Klaus Theweleit, *Male Fantasies*, vol. 1. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987.

———. *The Hearts of Men: American Dreams and the Flight from Commitment*. Garden City, NY: Anchor/Doubleday, 1983.

Elias, Norbert. *Über den Prozess der Zivilisation*. 2 vols. Basel: Haus zum Falken, 1939.

Emerson, Ralph Waldo. "Self-Reliance." In *Essays: First Series*. Boston: James Munroe, 1841.

Esposito, Roberto. *Communitas: Origine e destino della comunità*. Turin: Einaudi, 1998.

———. *Immunitas: Protezione e negazione della vita*. Turin: Einaudi, 2002.

Faludi, Susan. *Backlash: The Undeclared War Against American Women*. New York: Crown, 1991.

———. *Stiffed: The Betrayal of the American Man*. New York: William Morrow, 1999.

Fanon, Frantz. *Les Damnés de la terre*. Paris: Maspero, 1961.

Federici, Silvia. *Caliban and the Witch: Women, the Body and Primitive Accumulation*. Brooklyn: Autonomedia, 2004.

Fineman, Martha Albertson. "The Vulnerable Subject: Anchoring Equality in the Human Condition." *Yale Journal of Law and Feminism* 20, no. 1 (2008): 1–23.

Foucault, Michel. *Les Mots et les choses*. Paris: Gallimard, 1966.

———. *Naissance de la biopolitique: Cours au Collège de France, 1978–1979*. Paris: Gallimard/Seuil, 2004.

———. "Préface à la transgression." *Critique* 195–96 (1963).

———. *Le Souci de soi*. Paris: Gallimard, 1984.

———. "Technologies of the Self." In *Technologies of the Self*, edited by Luther H. Martin, Huck Gutman and Patrick H. Hutton. Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press, 1988.

Fraser, Nancy. "Behind Marx's Hidden Abode: For an Expanded Conception of Capitalism." *New Left Review* 86 (2014): 55–72.

———. *Cannibal Capitalism: How Our System Is Devouring Democracy, Care, and the Planet—and What We Can Do About It*. London: Verso, 2022.

Fraser, Nancy, and Rahel Jaeggi. *Capitalism: A Conversation in Critical Theory*. Cambridge: Polity, 2018.

Freud, Sigmund. "Fetischismus" (1927). *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur*. Vienna: Internationaler Psychoanalytischer Verlag, 1930.

Fricker, Miranda. *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007.

Fromm, Erich. *The Anatomy of Human Destructiveness*. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston, 1973.

———. *Man for Himself*. New York: Rinehart, 1947.

———. *To Have or to Be?* New York: Harper & Row, 1976.

Frye, Northrop. *Anatomy of Criticism*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1957.

Fukuyama, Francis. "The End of History?" *The National Interest* 16 (1989): 3–18.

———. *The End of History and the Last Man*. New York: Free Press, 1992.

Gilligan, Carol. *In a Different Voice*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982.

Girard, René. *Mensonge romantique et vérité romanesque*. Paris: Grasset, 1961.

———. *La Violence et le sacré*. Paris: Grasset, 1972.

Glenn, Evelyn Nakano. "From Servitude to Service Work: Historical Continuities in the Racial Division of Paid Reproductive Labor." *Signs* 18, no. 1 (1992): 1–43.

Goffman, Erving. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. Edinburgh: University of Edinburgh Social Sciences Research Centre, 1956.

Greenblatt, Stephen. *Renaissance Self-Fashioning: From More to Shakespeare*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980.

Haraway, Donna. "A Manifesto for Cyborgs." *Socialist Review* 80 (1985): 65–108.

Harvey, David. *The New Imperialism*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003.

Hayles, N. Katherine. *How We Became Posthuman*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1999.

Hegel, G. W. F. *Phänomenologie des Geistes*. Bamberg and Würzburg, 1807.

Heidegger, Martin. *Sein und Zeit*. Halle: Niemeyer, 1927.

Held, Virginia. *The Ethics of Care: Personal, Political, and Global*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006.

Hochschild, Arlie Russell. *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983.

Honneth, Axel. *Kampf um Anerkennung*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1992.

———. *Verdinglichung: Eine anerkennungstheoretische Studie*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 2005.

hooks, bell. *Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center*. Boston: South End Press, 1984.

———. *The Will to Change: Men, Masculinity, and Love*. New York: Atria Books, 2004.

Horkheimer, Max, and Theodor W. Adorno. *Dialektik der Aufklärung*. Amsterdam: Querido, 1947 (circulated 1944).

Hume, David. *A Treatise of Human Nature*. London, 1739–40.

Hutt, W. H. *Economists and the Public*. London: Jonathan Cape, 1936.

Huyssen, Andreas. *After the Great Divide: Modernism, Mass Culture, Postmodernism*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1986.

Jameson, Fredric. "Postmodernism, or the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism." *New Left Review* 146 (1984): 53–92.

———. *Postmodernism, or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism*. Durham: Duke University Press, 1991.

Kant, Immanuel. *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*. Riga: Hartknoch, 1785.

Kernberg, Otto. *Borderline Conditions and Pathological Narcissism*. New York: Jason Aronson, 1975.

Kierkegaard, Søren. *Enten–Eller* (*Either/Or*). Copenhagen, 1843.

———. *Sygdommen til Døden* (*The Sickness unto Death*). Copenhagen, 1849.

Kimmel, Michael. *Manhood in America: A Cultural History*. New York: Free Press, 1996.

Klein, Melanie. "Notes on Some Schizoid Mechanisms." *International Journal of Psycho-Analysis* 27 (1946): 99–110.

Kohut, Heinz. *The Analysis of the Self*. New York: International Universities Press, 1971.

Kojève, Alexandre. *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*. Paris: Gallimard, 1947.

Kolnai, Aurel. "Der Ekel." *Jahrbuch für Philosophie und phänomenologische Forschung* 10 (1929).

Kristeva, Julia. *Pouvoirs de l'horreur: Essai sur l'abjection*. Paris: Seuil, 1980.

Lacan, Jacques. "Kant avec Sade" (1963) and "Le stade du miroir comme formateur de la fonction du Je" (1949). In *Écrits*. Paris: Seuil, 1966.

Langton, Rae. *Sexual Solipsism: Philosophical Essays on Pornography and Objectification*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009.

———. "Speech Acts and Unspeakable Acts." *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 22, no. 4 (1993): 293–330.

Lasch, Christopher. *The Culture of Narcissism*. New York: Norton, 1979.

———. *The Minimal Self*. New York: Norton, 1984.

Levinas, Emmanuel. *Totalité et infini*. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1961.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. *Les Structures élémentaires de la parenté*. Paris: Presses Universitaires de France, 1949.

Lukács, Georg. *Geschichte und Klassenbewußtsein*. Berlin: Malik, 1923.

Macdonald, Dwight. "Masscult and Midcult." *Partisan Review* 27 (1960).

MacKinnon, Catharine A. *Feminism Unmodified*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987.

———. *Only Words*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1993.

———. *Toward a Feminist Theory of the State*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989.

Marcuse, Herbert. *Eros and Civilization*. Boston: Beacon Press, 1955.

———. *One-Dimensional Man*. Boston: Beacon Press, 1964.

Marx, Karl. *Das Kapital*. Vol. 1. Hamburg: Meissner, 1867. Vol. 3, edited by Friedrich Engels, 1894.

———. *Ökonomisch-philosophische Manuskripte* (1844; first published 1932).

Marx, Karl, and Friedrich Engels. *Die heilige Familie*. Frankfurt am Main: Rütten, 1845.

Mbembe, Achille. "Necropolitics." Trans. Libby Meintjes. *Public Culture* 15, no. 1 (2003): 11–40.

Medina, José. *The Epistemology of Resistance*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013.

Miller, William Ian. *The Anatomy of Disgust*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1997.

Millett, Kate. *Sexual Politics*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1970.

Mills, C. Wright. *White Collar: The American Middle Classes*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1951.

Mulvey, Laura. "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema." *Screen* 16, no. 3 (1975): 6–18.

Neale, Steve. "Masculinity as Spectacle." *Screen* 24, no. 6 (1983): 2–17.

Ngai, Sianne. *Ugly Feelings*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2005.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883–85); *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887).

Noddings, Nel. *Caring: A Feminine Approach to Ethics and Moral Education*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984.

Nussbaum, Martha C. *Hiding from Humanity: Disgust, Shame, and the Law*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2004.

———. "Objectification." *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 24, no. 4 (1995): 249–91.

———. *Women and Human Development: The Capabilities Approach*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2000.

Phelan, James. *Living to Tell About It: A Rhetoric and Ethics of Character Narration*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2005.

Pico della Mirandola, Giovanni. *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486; printed 1496).

Radford, Jill, and Diana E. H. Russell, eds. *Femicide: The Politics of Woman Killing*. New York: Twayne, 1992.

Riesman, David, with Nathan Glazer and Reuel Denney. *The Lonely Crowd*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1950.

Robinson, Sally. *Marked Men: White Masculinity in Crisis*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2000.

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. *Émile, ou De l'éducation*. 1762.

Rubin, Gayle. "Thinking Sex: Notes for a Radical Theory of the Politics of Sexuality." In Vance, *Pleasure and Danger*, 1984.

———. "The Traffic in Women: Notes on the 'Political Economy' of Sex." In *Toward an Anthropology of Women*, edited by Rayna R. Reiter, 157–210. New York: Monthly Review Press, 1975.

Ryle, Gilbert. *The Concept of Mind*. London: Hutchinson, 1949.

Sartre, Jean-Paul. *L'Être et le néant*. Paris: Gallimard, 1943.

———. *L'existentialisme est un humanisme*. Paris: Nagel, 1946.

Savran, David. *Taking It Like a Man: White Masculinity, Masochism, and Contemporary American Culture*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1998.

Schmitt, Carl. *Politische Theologie*. Munich: Duncker & Humblot, 1922.

Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. *Between Men: English Literature and Male Homosocial Desire*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1985.

———. *Epistemology of the Closet*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1990.

Simmel, Georg. "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben." In *Die Großstadt*, Jahrbuch der Gehe-Stiftung 9. Dresden, 1903.

———. *Philosophie des Geldes*. Leipzig: Duncker & Humblot, 1900.

Sloterdijk, Peter. *Kritik der zynischen Vernunft*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp, 1983.

Solanas, Valerie. *SCUM Manifesto*. New York: self-published, 1967; Olympia Press, 1968.

Sontag, Susan. *AIDS and Its Metaphors*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1989.

———. "The Pornographic Imagination." *Partisan Review* 34 (1967). Repr. in *Styles of Radical Will*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1969.

Strossen, Nadine. *Defending Pornography: Free Speech, Sex, and the Fight for Women's Rights*. New York: Scribner, 1995.

Theweleit, Klaus. *Männerphantasien*. 2 vols. Frankfurt am Main: Roter Stern, 1977–78. Trans. *Male Fantasies*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987–89.

Tronto, Joan C. *Moral Boundaries: A Political Argument for an Ethic of Care*. New York: Routledge, 1993.

Vance, Carole S., ed. *Pleasure and Danger: Exploring Female Sexuality*. Boston: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1984.

Veblen, Thorstein. *The Theory of Business Enterprise*. New York: Scribner's, 1904.

———. *The Theory of the Leisure Class*. New York: Macmillan, 1899.

Weber, Max. "Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus." *Archiv für Sozialwissenschaft und Sozialpolitik* 20–21 (1904–05). Trans. Talcott Parsons, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*. London: Allen & Unwin, 1930.

Williams, Linda. *Hard Core: Power, Pleasure, and the "Frenzy of the Visible."* Berkeley: University of California Press, 1989.

Willis, Ellen. "Feminism, Moralism, and Pornography." *Village Voice*, 1979. Repr. in *Beginning to See the Light*. New York: Knopf, 1981.

Wilson, Colin. *The Outsider*. London: Gollancz, 1956.

Wolf, Naomi. *The Beauty Myth*. London: Chatto & Windus, 1990.

Wolfe, Tom. "The 'Me' Decade and the Third Great Awakening." *New York*, 23 August 1976.

Wollstonecraft, Mary. *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman*. London: J. Johnson, 1792.

Wynter, Sylvia. "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom: Towards the Human, After Man, Its Overrepresentation—An Argument." *CR: The New Centennial Review* 3, no. 3 (2003): 257–337.

Žižek, Slavoj. *The Sublime Object of Ideology*. London: Verso, 1989.

IV. Literary, Cinematic, Musical, and Visual Works

Atwood, Margaret. *Alias Grace*. Toronto: McClelland & Stewart, 1996. Television adaptation directed by Mary Harron, written by Sarah Polley. CBC/Netflix, 2017.

Ballard, J. G. *Crash*. London: Jonathan Cape, 1973. Introduction to the French edition, 1974.

———. *Super-Cannes*. London: Flamingo, 2000.

Bataille, Georges. *Histoire de l'œil*. Paris, 1928.

Berg, Gretchen. "Nothing to Lose: An Interview with Andy Warhol." *Cahiers du Cinéma in English* 10 (1967).

Chernyshevsky, Nikolai. *What Is to Be Done?* 1863.

Conrad, Joseph. *Heart of Darkness*. 1899; book form 1902.

Cronenberg, David, dir. *Cosmopolis*. 2012.

Dante Alighieri. *Inferno*. c. 1308–21.

DeLillo, Don. *Cosmopolis*. New York: Scribner, 2003.

———. *White Noise*. New York: Viking, 1985.

De Palma, Brian, dir. *Body Double*. 1984.

Demme, Jonathan, dir. *The Silence of the Lambs*. 1991.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. *Crime and Punishment*. 1866.

———. *Notes from Underground*. 1864.

Dreiser, Theodore. *An American Tragedy*. New York: Boni & Liveright, 1925.

Fincher, David, dir. *Fight Club*. 1999.

Fitzgerald, F. Scott. *The Great Gatsby*. New York: Scribner's, 1925.

Flynn, Gillian. *Gone Girl*. New York: Crown, 2012.

Gide, André. *Les Caves du Vatican*. Paris: Gallimard, 1914.

Giotto di Bondone. Frescoes, Scrovegni (Arena) Chapel, Padua. Consecrated 1305.

Harris, Thomas. *Red Dragon*. New York: Putnam, 1981.

———. *The Silence of the Lambs*. New York: St. Martin's Press, 1988.

Harron, Mary, dir. *Charlie Says*. 2018.

———, dir. *Dalíland*. 2022.

———, dir. *I Shot Andy Warhol*. 1996.

———, dir. *The Moth Diaries*. 2011.

———, dir. *The Notorious Bettie Page*. 2005.

Hemingway, Ernest. *Death in the Afternoon*. New York: Scribner's, 1932.

Highsmith, Patricia. *The Talented Mr. Ripley*. New York: Coward-McCann, 1955.

Hitchcock, Alfred, dir. *Psycho*. 1960.

———, dir. *Rope*. 1948.

Homer. *Iliad*.

Hooper, Tobe, dir. *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*. 1974.

Houston, Whitney. "Greatest Love of All." *Whitney Houston*. Arista, 1985.

Huey Lewis and the News. "Hip to Be Square." *Fore!* Chrysalis, 1986.

Leonardo da Vinci. *Vitruvian Man*. c. 1490. Gallerie dell'Accademia, Venice.

Mailer, Norman. *An American Dream*. New York: Dial Press, 1965.

———. "The White Negro: Superficial Reflections on the Hipster." *Dissent* 4, no. 3 (1957).

Martin, Judith ("Miss Manners"). Syndicated etiquette column, cited as epigraph in Ellis, *American Psycho*.

Moshfegh, Ottessa. *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*. New York: Penguin Press, 2018.

Nabokov, Vladimir. *Lolita*. Paris: Olympia Press, 1955.

Ovid. *Metamorphoses*.

Palahniuk, Chuck. *Fight Club*. New York: Norton, 1996.

Petronius. *Satyricon*.

Phillips, Todd, dir. *Joker*. 2019.

Piesman, Marissa, and Marilee Hartley. *The Yuppie Handbook*. New York, 1984.

Pirandello, Luigi. *Come tu mi vuoi*. 1930.

Plautus. *Menaechmi*.

Réage, Pauline. *Histoire d'O*. Paris: Jean-Jacques Pauvert, 1954.

Rembrandt van Rijn. *The Anatomy Lesson of Dr. Nicolaes Tulp*. 1632. Mauritshuis, The Hague.

Sade, D. A. F. de. *Histoire de Juliette*. 1797–1801.

———. *Les 120 Journées de Sodome*. Written 1785; first published 1904.

Sartre, Jean-Paul. "Érostrate." In *Le Mur*. Paris: Gallimard, 1939.

———. *Huis clos*. 1944.

Scorsese, Martin, dir. *Taxi Driver*. 1976.

Shakespeare, William. *The Comedy of Errors*.

Swift, Jonathan. *A Modest Proposal*. Dublin, 1729.

Talking Heads. "(Nothing But) Flowers." *Naked*. Sire, 1988.

Thompson, Jim. *The Killer Inside Me*. New York: Lion Books, 1952.

Troche, Rose, dir. *Go Fish*. Written by Rose Troche and Guinevere Turner. 1994.

Trump, Donald J., with Tony Schwartz. *Trump: The Art of the Deal*. New York: Random House, 1987.

Vesalius, Andreas. *De humani corporis fabrica*. Basel: Oporinus, 1543.

Warhol, Andy. *The Philosophy of Andy Warhol (From A to B and Back Again)*. New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1975.

Whitman, Walt. *Leaves of Grass*. Brooklyn, 1855.

V. Legal and Historical Documents

American Booksellers Association, Inc. v. Hudnut, 771 F.2d 323 (7th Cir. 1985).

Holmes, Oliver Wendell. Letter to William T. G. Morton, November 1846.

Reagan, Ronald. "Address to the Nation on the Iran Arms and Contra Aid Controversy." 4 March 1987.

Keywords

American Psycho / Bret Easton Ellis / Mary Harron / Guinevere Turner / *homo anaestheticus* / anaesthetic sovereignty / aesthetics and anaesthetics / aesthesis / the itemized subject / credibility immunity / epistemic injustice / testimonial injustice / the cannibal ledger / cannibal capitalism / social reproduction / primitive accumulation / the absent referent / failed empirical metaphysics / somatic satire / stuplimity / abjection / the feminist remainder / the humanism of the *who* / narratable self / reading as exhumation / counter-adaptation / adaptation studies / commodity fetishism / reification / forgetfulness of recognition / simulacra and simulation / society of the spectacle / waning of affect / blasé attitude / conspicuous consumption / pseudo-individualization / narcissism of minor differences / mimetic desire / culture of narcissism / marketing character / necrophilous character / cynical reason / end of history / the last man / struggle for recognition / banality of evil / price and dignity / kingdom of ends / objectification / fungibility and violability / the face of the Other / Sadean apathy / transgression / *immunitas* and *communitas* / *homo sacer* / necropolitics / grievability / precarity / vulnerability theory / ethics of care / privileged irresponsibility / consumer sovereignty / human capital / economics of crime / capitalism as religion / male gaze / masculinity as spectacle / the Final Girl / ornamental culture / hegemonic masculinity / homosocial desire / traffic in women / feminist sex wars / anti-pornography feminism / speech act theory / femicide / sexual murder / serial-killer culture / unreliable narration / blank fiction / postmodern satire / Juvenalian satire / Menippean literalism / Renaissance humanism / Enlightenment humanism / existentialist humanism / radical humanism / decolonial humanism / posthumanism / neoliberalism / financialization / Reagan era / yuppie culture / memetic reception / perlocutionary capture

---

Set in TeX Gyre Pagella and TeX Gyre Heros Condensed. Trim size 7 × 10 inches. Eggshell pages, bone card, coulis red.

THIS IS NOT AN EXIT